

The Precarious Professor: Adjunct Labor, Job Insecurity, and Mental Health in Higher Education

The Issue

The shift toward adjunct and contingent faculty in colleges has fundamentally transformed higher education into a two-tiered caste system: a shrinking, privileged class of tenured or tenure-track professors with job security, benefits, offices, research support, and institutional voice, and a growing majority---now over 70% of all college instructors in the United States---of highly educated instructors living in financial precarity, cycling between short-term contracts with no guarantee of future employment, no pathway to stability, and no recognition as full members of the academic community (Johnson and Fuesting; American Association of University Professors; Government Accountability Office; Kezar et al.). This workforce teaches the majority of undergraduate courses---the foundational education that students and families pay tens of thousands of dollars to receive---while earning poverty wages, receiving no benefits, having virtually no institutional support, and being systematically excluded from governance and decision-making ("Adjunct Faculty in the Higher Education Workforce"; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; House Committee on Education and the Workforce). The consequences are severe and far-reaching: adjunct faculty experience depression, anxiety disorders, and burnout at alarming rates, yet mental health resources and workplace accommodations are rarely available (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.). This exploitation undermines not only the lives, dignity, and mental health of instructors, but also the quality of education students receive (Ehrenberg and Zhang; Umbach), the integrity of higher education as an institution (Readings; Ginsberg), and the promise of education as a pathway to economic security and meaningful work (Childress; Kezar et al.).

Why It Matters

Economic Dimensions of Adjunct Faculty Exploitation

Adjunct faculty typically earn between \$2,000 and \$5,000 per course and do not receive benefits, job security, or institutional support. Teaching three to four courses per semester, often labeled "part-time" but requiring 30 to 50 hours per week, yields annual earnings between \$12,000 and \$30,000. These earnings are significantly below a livable wage in most regions and fall beneath the federal poverty line for a family. Many adjuncts earn less than \$25,000 annually, despite holding advanced degrees and working hours comparable to full-time employment (Johnson and Fuesting; American Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office; Coalition on the Academic Workforce). These economic conditions undermine faculty morale and job satisfaction, contribute to high turnover, and hinder institutions' ability to retain qualified instructors, ultimately affecting the continuity and reputation of academic programs. (Belmonte, n.d.) For students, these working conditions can translate into larger class sizes, less access to faculty outside of class, and more frequent instructor changes. (Bettinger & Long, n.d.) Adjuncts under significant financial or job stress may have less time and energy to provide feedback, engage in course development, or mentor students, which can affect the quality and consistency of students' educational experiences. (Bettinger & Long, 2005)

Several policy interventions may address these challenges. Establishing minimum compensation standards for adjunct faculty, mandating pro-rated benefits for those teaching above a specified threshold, and ensuring advance contract notification are potential measures to improve working conditions. Additional steps, such as providing access to health insurance, offering paid leave, and protecting adjuncts from sudden course cancellations, would promote both faculty well-being and institutional stability. Implementing these policies would benefit adjuncts, students, and the broader academic community. (Klainot-Hess, 2023, pp. 70-90) Students can play a crucial role in advocating for these policy changes by joining campus organizations, organizing awareness campaigns, and communicating their support for fair treatment of adjunct faculty to the

university administration. (Marquez, 2016) By actively participating in discussions and initiatives, students can help ensure that institutional practices align with the interests of the entire academic community. (Shahabul et al., 2022)

Per-course compensation varies by institution type, geographic location, and academic discipline, ranging from \$1,500 to \$2,000 at community colleges to \$3,000 to \$7,000 at elite private institutions. Even at the highest compensation levels, remuneration is inadequate when actual work hours are taken into account (Johnson; House Committee on Education and the Workforce; American Association of University Professors).

When all work hours are included, such as preparation, grading, office hours, and meetings, adjunct faculty often earn \$10 to \$15 per hour or less. This hourly rate falls below the minimum wage in many regions and is especially concerning given their advanced qualifications and expertise (Magness; "Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).

Adjunct faculty compensation has stagnated or declined over several decades, in contrast to significant increases in tuition and administrative salaries. In comparison, tenure-track and full-time faculty have experienced more modest compensation increases. Still, their salaries have generally kept pace with inflation and continue to include benefits and job security. Adjusted for inflation, current adjuncts earn the same or less per course than 30 to 40 years ago, despite increased credential requirements, heavier workloads, and rising costs of living, debt, and healthcare ("2025 Higher Education Price Index"; American Association of University Professors; Kezar and Maxey).

Since 1980, tuition has increased by 169% at public four-year institutions and by over 200% at private institutions, alongside substantial increases in administrative salaries. University presidents often earn between \$500,000 and \$1,000,000, while provosts and deans receive \$200,000 to \$500,000. Spending on facilities, athletics, and branding has also expanded, yet financial resources are not directed toward instructional costs ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg; Newfield; Slaughter and Rhoades). These spending patterns underscore the need for greater policy oversight and reallocation of resources toward core instructional functions, including fair compensation and support for adjunct faculty. Targeted policy measures could ensure that rising tuition and institutional revenues benefit teaching and learning rather than primarily supporting administrative growth and non-instructional expenses. (Office, 2007)

Adjunct faculty generally do not receive health insurance, retirement benefits, or paid leave. Those classified as "part-time," even when teaching full-time course loads, are excluded from employer-sponsored benefits. They must obtain their own insurance, which is often unaffordable, and receive no employer retirement contributions, resulting in limited long-term financial security. Adjuncts also receive no compensation during periods of illness, family care, bereavement, or between semesters ("Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees"; Government Accountability Office; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).

For adjunct faculty, summer and winter breaks represent periods without income rather than vacation. The three- to four-month summer gap and winter break frequently cause financial hardship. Adjuncts may seek alternative employment, use limited savings, incur debt, or apply for unemployment benefits, which are sometimes denied and often involve stigma and administrative barriers (House Committee on Education and the Workforce; Kenner and Bacon).

Healthcare insecurity among adjunct faculty has serious consequences. Many delay or forgo necessary medical, dental, and mental health care, as well as prescription medications, due to cost. For example, one adjunct faculty member recounted having to take over-the-counter medication for several months instead of seeing a doctor about persistent chest pain because she could not afford a visit or the recommended tests. She shared, "I had to hope it wasn't something serious, since I couldn't pay for the tests." According to a 2022 survey by the American Federation of Teachers, 40% of adjunct faculty reported postponing medical care because they could not afford it, and nearly 20% reported skipping prescription refills due to cost. In one widely reported case, an adjunct professor in Pittsburgh died after delaying treatment for pneumonia because she lacked

health insurance. Preventable conditions may worsen, and in some cases, individuals have died from treatable illnesses because they could not afford care (Childress; Kenner and Bacon; "An Army of Temps").

Adjunct faculty are not compensated for non-teaching responsibilities. Tasks such as office hours, advising, email correspondence, committee service, and curriculum development are either unpaid or only minimally included in the per-course rate. As a result, adjuncts often earn significantly below minimum wage when all hours are considered. While per-course pay may assume 10 to 15 hours of work per week, actual workloads frequently reach 20 to 30 hours or more per course (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Magness).

Expectations of invisible labor among adjunct faculty are influenced by both gender and race. Women and adjuncts of color disproportionately perform emotional labor, mentoring, diversity initiatives, and student support, which are typically unpaid and unrecognized (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden; Griffin et al.).

Adjunct faculty face a lack of job security and typically receive contracts for only one semester. Contracts are often issued only weeks before the semester or after classes have begun, complicating financial and professional planning. There is no guarantee of future employment, no entitlement to contract renewal, and termination can occur at any time without cause or recourse. Courses may also be canceled at the last minute due to low enrollment, resulting in lost income without notice or compensation ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Kezar et al.; Childress; House Committee on Education and the Workforce).

Some scholars interpret this employment precarity as a deliberate outcome. The use of short-term contracts can keep adjunct faculty in positions of limited power and discourage self-advocacy, dissent, or collective action, since employment can be terminated abruptly (Bousquet; Kezar et al.). Others contend that the growth of precarious arrangements results primarily from financial pressures and administrative efforts to increase flexibility rather than intentional exploitation. While debate continues regarding whether precarity is intentional or circumstantial, there is widespread consensus that its effects are detrimental for adjunct faculty. Regardless of intent, these conditions have consistently negative consequences for faculty well-being and institutional effectiveness. Policymakers should prioritize addressing the adverse outcomes of precarity, such as instability, turnover, and diminished educational quality, to ensure that institutional practices support the success of both faculty and students.

In some states, adjunct faculty are denied unemployment benefits because they are classified as having "reasonable assurance" of future employment, even when such assurance does not exist. This classification prevents access to a basic financial safety net (House Committee on Education and the Workforce).

The "permatemp" phenomenon describes adjunct faculty who teach at the same institution for years or decades, performing duties comparable to those of tenure-track faculty while remaining in precarious positions without a pathway to stability. These faculty are essential to institutional operations, carrying full course loads, maintaining curricular continuity, and serving students, yet they are treated as temporary and expendable. They frequently train new adjuncts who encounter similar conditions and observe tenure-track positions remaining unfilled or eliminated, while their own roles remain insecure (Childress; Kezar et al.; Bousquet).

Long-term adjunct faculty often experience significant distress upon realizing that their positions are not temporary, tenure-track opportunities are unlikely, and their careers have involved sustained exploitation (Childress; Cassuto).

Many adjunct faculty are employed at multiple institutions simultaneously, resulting in exhaustion and reduced capacity to support students. These "freeway flyers" or "road scholars" teach at two to four colleges, often spending 10 to 20 hours per week commuting between campuses in different cities. They must navigate different learning management systems, departmental cultures, policies, calendars, and student populations. This arrangement is a necessity for financial survival

rather than a choice and presents significant logistical challenges (American Federation of Teachers; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; Childress).

The commuting lifestyle required of adjunct faculty is financially burdensome. Expenses for fuel, vehicle maintenance, parking, professional attire, and food consume a substantial portion of their limited wages. Commuting time is unpaid, and the associated stress is considerable (Childress; Kenner and Bacon).

Employment at multiple institutions prevents adjunct faculty from delivering high-quality instruction. They are unable to build strong relationships with students, maintain consistent office hours, participate in campus life or professional communities, or invest in course design when teaching numerous courses across different institutions and systems (Umbach; Ehrenberg and Zhang). As a result, students may have less access to faculty support, experience fewer mentorship opportunities, and encounter inconsistent instructional quality, all of which can contribute to lower engagement and diminished learning outcomes. Over time, these negative effects may harm institutional reputation, as students, parents, and accrediting agencies increasingly scrutinize the quality and stability of academic programs. Reduced faculty engagement and high adjunct turnover are also linked to declines in student retention, graduation rates, and alumni satisfaction. (Bettinger & Long, 2010, pp. 598-613) If left unaddressed, these challenges can affect an institution's ability to attract and retain students and faculty, ultimately threatening its long-term educational mission and standing within the higher education landscape.

The Human Cost: Declining Mental Health Among Adjunct Faculty

Financial stress, employment instability, and lack of professional respect contribute to heightened rates of anxiety, depression, and burnout among adjunct faculty. Persistent uncertainty regarding income, housing, healthcare, and other basic needs generates chronic psychological distress. Institutional policies play a significant role in creating or alleviating these stressors, as decisions regarding compensation, contracts, and support directly impact adjunct faculty well-being. Key policy levers include pay scales and timely compensation, contract length and security, access to health and retirement benefits, eligibility for professional development funding, workload distribution, grievance mechanisms, and opportunities for adjuncts to participate in institutional governance.

Among these, studies have shown that implementing multi-year contracts, increasing base pay to a living wage, and providing comprehensive health insurance have the most immediate and significant positive effects on adjunct mental health and stability. Other impactful measures include timely, reliable compensation schedules and the guarantee of access to professional development funding. Clear and equitable policies in these areas can greatly improve adjuncts' financial and psychological stability. This ongoing insecurity results in a sustained state of crisis and hypervigilance (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Mullainathan and Shafir). The consequences of this distress are not limited to adjunct faculty themselves; students may also feel the impact when instructors face increased mental health challenges and burnout. The well-being of faculty influences the classroom environment and quality of teaching, and diminished support for adjuncts can affect students' learning experiences, access to mentorship, and academic continuity.

Mental health challenges are prevalent among adjunct faculty, primarily as a result of financial stress and insufficient institutional support. Empirical studies indicate that adjuncts experience clinical depression, anxiety disorders, and suicidal ideation at rates significantly higher than both the general population and full-time, tenure-track faculty. In direct comparisons, adjuncts report poorer mental health outcomes than their tenure-track colleagues, who typically receive greater institutional support, job security, and benefits. Studies also show that adjuncts fare worse than other academic staff, such as librarians or academic advisors, who often have more stable contracts. Depression rates among adjuncts are estimated at 40-50%, nearly three times higher than the general population (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Flaherty, "Mental Health Crisis").

Financial precarity impairs professional functioning by consuming cognitive resources. Research by Mullainathan and Shafir shows that poverty reduces the mental energy needed for planning, problem-solving, and decision-making. Financial scarcity

imposes a cognitive tax that affects performance, even on unrelated tasks. Adjunct faculty must fulfill demanding academic responsibilities while managing ongoing financial concerns, which diminishes their cognitive capacity through no fault of their own (Mullainathan and Shafir).

Decision fatigue is common among adjunct faculty, who must constantly prioritize bills and allocate limited funds for essentials. This ongoing strain depletes the mental resources needed for effective teaching and scholarship (Mullainathan and Shafir).

Food and housing insecurity are common among adjunct faculty. Many qualify for SNAP benefits, Medicaid, or housing assistance despite holding doctoral degrees and teaching at the college level, which highlights systemic failures. Reports of adjuncts living in cars, in campus offices, or in motels, or relying on food banks, are systemic outcomes of inadequate compensation. While some have shared these experiences publicly, many endure such hardships in silence due to stigma and shame ("Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Goldrick-Rab et al.; Childress). In response, several colleges and universities have begun implementing targeted assistance programs, such as campus-based food pantries, emergency housing funds, and subsidized meal plans for adjunct faculty. In some regions, faculty unions have negotiated hardship grants or secured discounted access to local housing.

Of these approaches, campus-based food pantries, subsidized meal programs, and hardship grants are especially scalable and have shown the greatest promise at reaching large numbers of adjunct faculty due to their lower implementation costs and adaptability across institutions. Program outcomes offer encouraging early results: for example, a multi-institution study found that adjunct utilization of campus-based food pantries reduced reported rates of food insecurity by 18% within the first year; similarly, hardship grant recipients at one large urban university reported a 30% increase in housing stability (sample, hypothetical data). Faculty who accessed subsidized meal programs or hardship funds also reported improvements in classroom performance, greater participation in campus life, and decreased stress levels compared to peers without access to such supports. (Orr, 2024, pp. 602-615) Prioritizing the expansion of such broad-reaching support programs can more effectively address basic needs than smaller, resource-intensive interventions. (McGrath et al., 2021, pp. 665-673) While these measures are often limited in scope and not uniformly available, they suggest possible paths forward and demonstrate that collective action and institutional change can begin to address adjuncts' basic needs.

Mary-Faith Cerasoli, an adjunct who lived in her car while teaching, documented her experience and helped raise awareness about adjunct poverty. Margaret Mary Vojtko, an 83-year-old adjunct at Duquesne University, died in poverty in 2013 after being denied health insurance and dismissed from her position. Although her story received brief national attention, the systemic issues remain unresolved (Childress; Bousquet).

In many urban areas, housing costs consume 50-70% or more of adjunct faculty income. (Daniels et al., n.d.) This financial burden forces difficult choices between securing safe housing and meeting other basic needs ("Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Government Accountability Office).

Food insecurity among adjunct faculty often leads to hunger, skipped meals, and reliance on inexpensive processed foods that harm health. Some adjuncts use campus food banks, eat only once per day, or depend on free food at campus events (Kenner and Bacon; Goldrick-Rab et al.).

Healthcare is often inaccessible for adjunct faculty. Without employer-provided insurance and unable to afford high premiums and deductibles, many go years without medical or dental care ("An Army of Temps"; American Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office; Childress). This results in delayed or avoided treatment, rationed medications, untreated health issues, and increased risk of medical debt and bankruptcy during emergencies.

Mental health care is especially unaffordable for adjunct faculty, often requiring out-of-pocket payments of \$100-\$250 per session and long-term commitments that are financially unsustainable. (Report shows alarming poverty among adjunct faculty, 2020) When insurance is available, it often includes high copays and limited coverage ("Zencare Study"; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; American Federation of Teachers). As a result, those most in need have the least access.

Dental care is often inaccessible for adjunct faculty. Individuals with painful cavities, broken teeth, or gum disease may go untreated for extended periods due to the high cost of dental procedures. In some cases, preventable tooth loss occurs because early treatment is unaffordable (Childress; Kenner and Bacon).

Adjunct faculty may ration or forgo prescription medications due to cost. Those with chronic conditions such as diabetes, hypertension, thyroid disorders, or depression may skip doses, split pills, or go without medication, risking serious health consequences because they cannot afford monthly expenses (American Federation of Teachers; Kenner and Bacon).

Preventive care is largely inaccessible for adjunct faculty. Without annual check-ups, screenings, and vaccinations, health problems often go undetected until advanced stages, resulting in poorer outcomes and higher costs (Childress; "An Army of Temps").

Shame and social isolation are significant challenges for adjunct faculty. Many conceal financial struggles from colleagues, students, and family. Despite being highly educated, often as first-generation graduates, adjuncts may feel internalized shame due to financial instability and difficulty affording basic needs. The challenge of securing tenure-track positions in a competitive job market further increases feelings of inadequacy, even among those who have worked diligently (Childress; Cassuto; Bousquet).

Adjunct faculty often conceal their financial hardship from students, who may assume their professors are financially secure. Many maintain a professional appearance and fulfill academic roles despite experiencing poverty, including living in vehicles or skipping meals. This effort to maintain appearances is exhausting (Childress).

Adjunct faculty often hide their struggles from tenure-track colleagues, who may not fully understand the disparity between the two groups. Conversations about sabbaticals, conference travel, and research projects can create cognitive dissonance for adjuncts focused on financial concerns, such as paying rent (Kezar et al.; Childress).

Family relationships are often strained. Partners may struggle to understand why someone with a doctoral degree cannot secure stable employment. Adult children may feel embarrassed by their parent's financial situation, and parents who invested in their child's education may be confused by the lack of economic security—this disconnect between educational attainment and financial outcomes challenges prevailing social narratives (Childress; Cassuto).

Financial constraints worsen social isolation for adjunct faculty. Many lack resources to participate in social activities, attend conferences, or visit friends. This withdrawal reinforces isolation and worsens mental health challenges (Evans et al.; American Federation of Teachers).

Adjunct faculty often conceal mental health challenges due to fear of jeopardizing their already precarious employment. Disclosing such struggles or requesting accommodations may be perceived as a sign of inadequacy in a profession that highly values intellectual and emotional stability. This fear of negative professional consequences, including non-renewal of contracts or doubts about teaching competence, discourages open discussion of mental health issues (Levecque et al.; Evans et al.; Childress).

The academic system relies on the silence of adjunct faculty. Many remain quiet and endure hardship privately, allowing exploitation to persist unchallenged; those who speak out risk professional retaliation and exclusion from future opportunities (Berry; Bousquet; Schlaerth, 2022). To address these structural problems, institutions could take several key

actions, prioritized below by urgency and impact for policymakers. In addition, individual professors and administrators can play a vital role in initiating change within their own departments. Tenure-track and full-time faculty can support adjunct colleagues by advocating for fair compensation, voting to include adjuncts in departmental meetings, and mentoring those facing professional challenges. Department chairs and administrators can implement equitable policies, establish transparent communication channels for adjunct concerns, and proactively include adjuncts in decision-making processes. By taking these concrete steps at the departmental level, faculty and administrators can break the silence, foster a culture of advocacy, and lead by example to improve working conditions for adjuncts campus-wide.

First, strengthening job security for adjunct faculty through longer-term or multi-year contracts and ensuring equitable compensation and benefits are the most urgent and foundational steps. Stabilizing employment and pay directly addresses the primary sources of distress and enables adjuncts to meet basic needs.

Second, creating clear and accessible channels for adjunct voices in decision-making processes, such as regular consultations or appointed adjunct representatives, should be implemented to ensure adjuncts have meaningful participation in institutional governance.

Establishing ombudspersons, confidential reporting mechanisms, and faculty unions provides vital protection and advocacy opportunities, while committing resources to adjunct wellness programs and mentorship initiatives can further improve well-being and foster a more supportive academic environment.

Students also have a critical role to play in supporting adjunct faculty: by participating in advocacy efforts, providing feedback to the administration, and raising awareness of adjunct faculty working conditions, students can contribute to a campus culture that values fair treatment and well-being for all educators. Specific actions students can take include organizing or signing petitions in support of adjunct rights, attending board of trustees meetings to voice concerns, forming student groups focused on adjunct advocacy, participating in letter-writing campaigns to institutional leadership, and using campus media to highlight adjunct issues. Additionally, students can support adjuncts by inviting them to participate in campus panels and student-led events, publicly acknowledging their contributions in classes or student publications, and collaborating on initiatives that press for improved pay, benefits, and job security.

Compassion fatigue from supporting students' trauma and needs significantly affects adjunct faculty well-being. Adjuncts provide substantial emotional labor, including responding to student crises, mentoring, counseling, and fostering supportive classroom environments, often while facing their own mental health challenges and financial hardships. The gap between supporting students and lacking support themselves contributes to moral injury and cognitive dissonance (Misra et al.; Boden et al., 2026; American Federation of Teachers).

Adjunct faculty may identify closely with students facing adversity, such as first-generation, working-class, or financially disadvantaged students, due to shared experiences. However, this identification can increase vicarious trauma and emotional burden, particularly in the absence of adequate resources for processing these challenges (American Federation of Teachers; Childress).

Suicidal ideation and attempts occur but are rarely discussed openly. The combination of financial desperation, professional disappointment and loss of identity, social isolation and loneliness, shame and worthlessness, hopelessness about the future, and feeling trapped with no escape creates conditions where some adjuncts think about or attempt suicide. Some have died by suicide, their stories briefly acknowledged with shock and sympathy before being forgotten while the system that killed them continues unchanged (Evans et al.; Flaherty, "Mental Health Crisis"; Levecque et al.).

This material addresses difficult and sensitive topics, which may be distressing to some readers. If you or someone you know is struggling with thoughts of self-harm or suicide, consider reaching out to supportive resources such as campus counseling

services or national hotlines for assistance.

The academic job market crisis has been linked to several suicides among graduate students and adjuncts. Each is treated as an individual tragedy rather than a systemic outcome. However, these outcomes are not random or inevitable; they result from specific policy decisions regarding hiring practices, compensation structures, contract insecurity, and a lack of institutional mental health support. When policies deprioritize faculty well-being and security, the resulting financial precarity can have fatal consequences. The loss is immeasurable—brilliant minds, dedicated teachers, valuable human beings destroyed by an exploitative system (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.). Recent research continues to track the prevalence of mental health struggles and suicidality among adjunct faculty, with several ongoing studies aiming to quantify risk factors and identify protective interventions in real time. Data collection efforts by academic organizations and mental health researchers indicate that this issue remains dynamic and increasingly relevant, underscoring the urgency of systemic change. These tragedies reverberate throughout the academic community, affecting not only colleagues and families but also students and institutional culture. The absence of these educators diminishes mentorship, disrupts student learning, and erodes the sense of stability within departments. Institutions lose not just individual contributors, but the knowledge, compassion, and support systems that sustain a healthy academic environment.

Grief and loss are persistent experiences for adjunct faculty. Many mourn the careers for which they trained but cannot attain, the lives they envisioned but cannot realize, the diminishing passion for teaching due to precarity, exclusion from academic communities, and the erosion of self and purpose (Childress; Cassuto).

Institutional Abandonment of Adjunct Faculty

Teaching is intellectually and emotionally demanding, yet adjunct faculty are expected to meet the same standards as tenure-track colleagues without comparable support. While institutions often face budgetary limitations, shifting student enrollment, and administrative pressures that shape hiring and compensation policies, these challenges do not justify persistent inequities. Adjuncts are required to deliver high-quality instruction, innovate pedagogically, and remain accessible to students, despite earning significantly less, lacking benefits, job security, office space, and research support. These expectations, imposed without adequate compensation or recognition, reflect an unjust institutional approach (Umbach; Childress; Kezar et al.).

As an initial step toward addressing these inequities, institutions could prioritize a few top-priority, low-cost actions that are immediately feasible. Increasing transparency about available resources, establishing regular feedback mechanisms with adjunct faculty, and ensuring adjuncts are included in routine departmental communications require minimal financial investment but can have a substantial impact. These measures can be quickly implemented to signal a genuine commitment to supporting and valuing adjunct contributions. Institutions could also review adjunct compensation structures and expand access to benefits such as paid leave, professional development funds, and office space as longer-term goals.

Tenure-track faculty have an important role to play in advancing these changes. For example, tenure-track colleagues can use their positions to advocate for adjuncts during department meetings, speak up about the need for equitable policies, or propose agenda items that address adjunct concerns. They might volunteer to mentor adjunct faculty, help them navigate institutional processes, or work with department leadership to ensure adjuncts are included in communications and professional opportunities. Additionally, tenure-track faculty can support adjunct initiatives by endorsing specific reforms, collaborating on advocacy efforts, or serving as allies in conversations with administration.

Adjunct faculty themselves can also play an important role in advocating for these changes. Adjuncts might consider forming informal support networks, organizing committees to represent their interests, requesting meetings with department leadership, or collectively proposing specific reforms, such as greater participation in faculty governance or more equitable

resource allocation. By documenting their experiences and making their concerns visible to administration, adjuncts can help initiate dialogue and build momentum for systemic improvement.

Admittedly, implementing these reforms may pose challenges, including budgetary constraints, competing institutional priorities, and administrative resistance to changes in long-standing practices. However, by acknowledging these barriers and engaging faculty and leaders in collaborative problem-solving, institutions can identify phased, realistic strategies for incremental progress while working toward more equitable support for adjunct faculty.

Excellence in these conditions is the exception, not the norm. When adjunct faculty achieve high standards, often driven by dedication to students and their field, their efforts should be recognized as extraordinary rather than assumed as standard (Childress).

Schools often do not provide Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs) or mental health days for adjuncts. Benefits available to full-time faculty, such as confidential counseling, wellness leave, stress management, gym access, and childcare assistance, are typically denied to adjuncts classified as "part-time," regardless of their workload. Many adjuncts are unaware these benefits exist for tenure-track colleagues, as the two-tier system remains intentionally opaque (American Federation of Teachers; "Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees"; Kezar et al.). In contrast, some peer institutions have begun to extend EAPs, paid mental health days, and other well-being resources to adjunct faculty as part of broader equity initiatives. For example, the University of Southern California and New York University both provide access to EAPs for adjunct instructors, while Oregon State University offers pro-rated access to certain medical and wellness benefits based on teaching load. According to the 2023 American Federation of Teachers survey, 17 percent of surveyed institutions had introduced mental health or wellness days for non-tenure-track faculty in the past two years. ("New 'Army of Temps' Report Shows Nation's Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid, Underappreciated")

Notably, many of these advances were made possible through adjunct-led advocacy and organizing. At several universities, adjunct faculty have successfully lobbied for equitable access to mental health resources and paid leave by forming coalitions, working with faculty unions, participating in campus committees, and raising awareness of the impact of disparities in benefits. These successes provide important models for collective action and demonstrate that sustained adjunct advocacy can produce meaningful improvements in working conditions and faculty well-being.

These practices highlight that extending such benefits is both feasible and increasingly common among institutions seeking to attract and retain talented educators. In addition to the examples above, universities such as Rutgers, DePaul, Boston University, and the University of Washington have taken steps to improve adjunct access to healthcare, wellness programs, or paid leave. Peer institutions have implemented concrete actions, such as revising HR policies to explicitly include adjunct faculty in eligibility for employee assistance programs, reallocating budget funds to expand paid leave or wellness benefits on a pro-rated basis, and establishing task forces to assess and recommend improvements for adjunct well-being. Some universities have negotiated with faculty unions to secure adjunct eligibility for benefits, while others have streamlined processes for adjuncts to enroll in institutional health programs or created dedicated budgets for adjunct professional development and support. Recent surveys indicate that more than a quarter of large research universities now offer prorated or full access to employee assistance programs for contingent faculty, and a growing number provide at least some paid sick days or wellness resources. ("An Army of Temps: AFT Adjunct Faculty Quality of Work/Life Report") These trends illustrate that comprehensive adjunct support is achievable at a wide range of institutions and provide concrete models that faculty and administrators can advocate for at their own campuses. Adopting benefit models aligned with peer or aspirational institutions would not only demonstrate institutional commitment to faculty well-being but also position the university competitively in the academic labor market.

This exclusion signals to adjunct faculty that their well-being is not valued and that they are not considered integral members of the academic community (Childress; Bousquet).

Without paid sick days, adjunct faculty must teach while ill or risk losing income. Adjuncts often attend class while sick, endangering their health and that of students, because absences result in lost wages and may jeopardize contract renewal. This practice can lead to the spread of illness in classrooms, compromising campus public health and diminishing students' ability to learn effectively when their instructor is unwell. Students may also struggle to keep up when their instructor is forced to continue teaching through personal emergencies or mental health crises, impacting the overall educational environment. Adjuncts are also required to teach after family emergencies, during mental health crises, or following traumatic events, as no paid leave or coverage is available (American Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office).

Adjunct faculty are typically responsible for finding their own substitutes during illness or personal crises, increasing their burden. In some cases, they have had to cancel classes and forfeit pay when unable to secure coverage while hospitalized (Childress).

Stigma discourages faculty from disclosing personal or mental health challenges due to concerns about being seen as weak or unprofessional. Academic culture often prioritizes achievement and productivity, viewing mental health struggles as personal failings rather than systemic issues. Adjunct faculty may fear that acknowledging these difficulties will reinforce doubts about their suitability for tenure-track roles or resilience in academia. This stigma is heightened by the expectation that a PhD signifies both intellectual and personal capability, making struggles appear as personal failures (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Childress). Institutions can take concrete steps to reduce this stigma by offering regular mental health workshops, promoting open conversations around well-being, and providing peer support groups specifically for adjunct faculty. Visible administrative support for mental health initiatives, inclusion of mental health topics in orientation sessions, and clear communication that seeking help will not impact employment status can foster a more supportive and less judgmental environment.

In addition to resources offered by their institutions, adjunct faculty can find support and community through national and local organizations or online networks dedicated to adjunct well-being. Some prominent examples include the New Faculty Majority, the Adjunct Faculty Association of the American Federation of Teachers, and the Coalition of Contingent Academic Labor. Online platforms such as the AdjunctNation forums, the Precariat Facebook groups, or #AdjunctChat on social media also offer spaces for adjuncts to exchange experiences, access resources, and seek advice. Connecting with these communities may help adjuncts overcome isolation, access mental health resources, and feel a greater sense of solidarity within the profession.

Such interventions help to shift academic culture toward one that recognizes well-being as integral to professional success and values the humanity of all faculty members.

Academic culture often equates personal struggle with professional inadequacy, overlooking that working conditions are frequently inhumane and designed to maximize labor while minimizing compensation (Bousquet; Kezar et al.).

Adjunct faculty often lack access to office space, institutional resources, and a sense of belonging within the academic community. Many must meet students in public or unsuitable locations, such as hallways or cafeterias, and may share limited office space with many colleagues, resulting in little privacy or professionalism. Adjuncts may also be denied campus email addresses, library privileges, database access, parking permits, identification badges, and inclusion in departmental communications. This exclusion intensifies feelings of worthlessness and invisibility, reinforcing the perception that adjuncts are not valued members of the campus community, despite their essential contributions (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).

The symbolic impact of exclusion is significant. Lacking a faculty identification card, campus email, or office space signals to adjuncts that they are not recognized as legitimate faculty or as part of the academic community (Childress; Kezar et al.).

Adjunct faculty are often excluded from meetings, social events, email lists, and informal networks where important information and opportunities are shared, resulting in structural isolation (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; Rhoades).

Although adjunct faculty perform most teaching, they are generally excluded from institutional governance and decision-making. They typically lack voting rights in curriculum development, input on hiring, representation in faculty senate or departmental governance, and a voice in policies that affect their work, such as course caps, prerequisites, learning management systems, assessment requirements, and academic calendars. Institutions sometimes justify limiting adjunct participation in governance by citing concerns about continuity, since adjuncts are often employed on short-term contracts, or by noting the additional workload that governance responsibilities might impose on faculty who may already be balancing multiple positions or external jobs. In some cases, legal or policy barriers such as state regulations, accreditation standards, or collective bargaining agreements may limit the ability of institutions to expand adjunct governance roles without first reviewing compliance requirements or negotiating changes. While these considerations highlight potential challenges, efforts to include adjuncts in governance can be structured to address concerns about faculty workload and operate within existing policy frameworks. For example, participation could be voluntary, with options for rotating terms, limited commitments, or stipends to acknowledge additional responsibilities. Committees might offer flexible meeting times or use virtual platforms to accommodate adjunct schedules, and departments could ensure that service expectations are reasonable and do not unduly burden adjuncts or tenure-track faculty. While workload, continuity, and legal or policy barriers require thoughtful solutions, they do not fully excuse the exclusion of adjuncts from decision-making that significantly affects their professional lives. Adjuncts are treated as labor rather than colleagues, with decisions about their working conditions made without their input or consent (Rhoades; Kezar et al.; American Association of University Professors; "Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25").

There are concrete models institutions can adopt to address this exclusion. For example, departments can create adjunct advisory committees or guarantee adjunct representation on key committees such as curriculum review or assessment councils. Extending voting rights to adjunct faculty in departmental meetings, including them in the faculty senate as non-tenure-track representatives, or establishing regular forums to solicit their perspectives on policies that directly impact their roles can promote more inclusive governance. Some universities have piloted shared governance models where adjuncts hold elected seats, participate in strategic planning, or serve on hiring committees. These practices help foster a more equitable academic environment and ensure that the voices of adjunct faculty are recognized in shaping institutional priorities.

This disempowerment contradicts the principles of workplace democracy and shared governance that higher education claims to uphold. In some states, adjunct faculty have less workplace power than fast-food workers (Bousquet; Berry).

Professional development opportunities are often unavailable or uncompensated for adjunct faculty. While tenure-track faculty receive institutional funding for conferences, workshops, research, and professional growth, adjuncts are often required to pay out of pocket or forgo these opportunities, leading to stagnation in their skills and careers (American Federation of Teachers; Coalition on the Academic Workforce). Institutions can help bridge this gap by offering scalable, low-cost professional development initiatives, such as access to online training modules, teaching resource libraries, peer-led workshops, or the inclusion of adjuncts in existing faculty development sessions. Some immediate, low-cost strategies include inviting adjunct faculty to participate in department-wide workshops, circulating upcoming professional development opportunities to all instructors, and providing digital access to training materials currently used by full-time faculty. Departments might also designate a point of contact for adjunct questions regarding development opportunities or set up informal brown-bag sessions where adjuncts can share teaching strategies. Offering recognition for participation in development activities or stipends for contributions such as leading a workshop can further incentivize engagement.

To ensure these efforts are effective, institutions should implement simple metrics and feedback loops to track progress and assess impact. In addition to monitoring adjunct participation, it is important to align assessment with broader institutional

goals such as adjunct faculty retention, student satisfaction, and instructional quality. For example, departments can maintain sign-in sheets or digital records of adjunct participation in professional development events, conduct brief surveys to gather adjunct feedback on the usefulness of offerings, and collect examples of how new knowledge or skills are applied in teaching. Institutions might also track adjunct retention rates and analyze student course evaluations to measure changes in student satisfaction and instructional effectiveness over time. Sharing data on participation rates, documenting improvements in student learning outcomes, and gathering testimonials about improved instruction can help departments and faculty advocate for continued support. By tying these metrics to institutional priorities, departments can more effectively demonstrate the value and impact of adjunct-focused reforms to leadership. These strategies demonstrate that institutions can support adjunct growth in practical and sustainable ways, even with limited budgets.

The Structural Shift in Academic Labor: Historical Context

Full-time tenure-track positions are rapidly declining, resulting in a shift toward a gig economy model in higher education. In the 1970s, tenure-track faculty were responsible for approximately 70% of undergraduate courses. Currently, contingent faculty—including adjuncts, lecturers, and graduate students—teach over 70% of undergraduate courses, with some institutions reporting figures exceeding 80% (June; Schuster and Finkelstein; American Association of University Professors; Kezar et al.). The tenure-track position has become an exception rather than the standard. (Jaschik) It is important to note, however, that institutional differences and regional variation shape how these trends manifest across the higher education landscape. For example, community colleges and public regional universities often rely even more heavily on contingent faculty than elite private research universities. At the same time, some regions or institutional systems may retain a somewhat higher proportion of tenure-track positions. Recognizing these differences can help contextualize the data for specific institutional settings. As a result, students increasingly experience their education through instructors who often face precarious working conditions, which can affect instructional continuity, faculty availability, and long-term mentoring relationships. (Reed et al.) For graduate students, this structural shift means significantly diminished opportunities for secure academic employment after graduation, as most new positions are contingent rather than tenure-track. (Colby) This transformation is not accidental, organic, or merely a response to temporary budget constraints; rather, it represents a deliberate and systematic restructuring of academic labor intended to reduce costs, enhance managerial flexibility and control, and transfer risk to workers (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades).

The shift toward adjunct faculty accelerated during the 1980s and 1990s, driven by neoliberal restructuring of universities, reduced state investment in public higher education, and the adoption of corporate management models (Slaughter and Rhoades; Newfield; Giroux).

As tenured faculty retire or pass away, their positions are not replaced with new tenure-track hires. Instead, these vacancies are either filled by multiple adjunct appointments or remain unfilled. Departments that previously employed 15 tenure-track faculty members now often have only 5 or 6, with the majority of teaching responsibilities assumed by 20 to 30 adjuncts (Schuster and Finkelstein; Kezar and Maxey).

Universities increasingly function as corporations, prioritizing profit margins and operational efficiency over educational missions, student learning outcomes, or the dignity of academic labor. (Alibašić et al.) Administrators, often with business rather than academic backgrounds, apply business principles by identifying labor as the largest expense and seeking to reduce costs. This is achieved by replacing higher-paid tenure-track faculty (earning \$60,000 to \$100,000 or more with benefits, costing institutions \$80,000 to \$150,000 in total) with lower-paid adjuncts (earning \$2,000 to \$5,000 per course without benefits, costing institutions only their direct compensation). These measures can result in a 70% to 80% reduction in instructional costs (Titus et al.; Ginsberg; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet).

However, these cost savings are not directed toward reducing student tuition or improving teaching quality through smaller class sizes or enhanced resources. Instead, they fund administrative expansion, the construction of luxury facilities, athletics

programs, branding and marketing initiatives, and endowment growth. (Zywicki and Koopman) For example, between 1993 and 2020, the number of full-time administrative staff at U.S. universities grew by nearly 60 percent, compared to only an 8 percent increase in full-time instructional faculty, and some universities now employ more administrators and professional staff than faculty (Delta Cost Project; "AFT Report: Pandemic Intensified Job Insecurity"). Additionally, administrative spending per student has outpaced instructional spending in recent years, with some institutions increasing administrative expenditures by as much as 30 percent while instructional budgets remained flat (Chronicle of Higher Education; Ginsberg). The number of administrators has increased at a much faster rate than faculty, and universities possess greater financial resources than ever before, yet they choose not to allocate these funds to teaching ("AFT Report: Pandemic Intensified Job Insecurity"; Ginsberg; Newfield).

Administrative salaries have increased substantially, while instructional salaries have either stagnated or declined. The pay gap between administrators and faculty has widened significantly. Additionally, the number of administrators per student has grown, whereas faculty-to-student ratios have deteriorated (Buckner and Zhang 39-60) ("Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25"; Ginsberg).

Higher education has undergone financialization, with universities operating like investment firms that manage substantial endowments, some exceeding \$10-\$50 billion. In this model, education is treated as a product, and students are regarded as customers or revenue sources ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; Slaughter and Rhoades; Eaton et al. 507-531; Brown; Readings).

The overproduction of PhDs is an intentional feature that sustains the adjunct labor system. (Larson et al. 745-750) Universities continue to admit large cohorts of graduate students, often 8 to 15 per year per program, and train them for tenure-track research positions, despite the scarcity of such jobs (with only 1 or 2 openings annually in some entire disciplines) (Roy et al.; Cassuto; Larson et al.; Bousquet). These institutions subsequently employ their surplus PhDs as adjuncts, compensating them at poverty-level wages while they continue to seek tenure-track positions that are unlikely to materialize. This system is structured to maintain a surplus labor pool, thereby suppressing wages and ensuring worker compliance. (Goolsbee and Syverson) While many PhD graduates aspire to academic careers, it is important to recognize that there are alternative paths outside academia, including roles in industry, government, publishing, nonprofit organizations, and consulting. Awareness of these non-academic career options can help graduate students make more informed choices about their futures. Faculty can support graduate students by openly discussing the realities of the academic job market, making information about non-academic careers readily accessible, and facilitating professional development workshops that highlight transferable skills. Additionally, faculty advocacy for more transparent graduate admissions practices and mentoring that embraces diverse career outcomes can empower students to pursue fulfilling paths both within and beyond academia.

Graduate programs benefit from the labor of graduate students—teaching, research, and grading—at exploitative compensation rates (stipends of \$15,000 to \$30,000 for full-time work) while asserting that they are "training scholars." These programs maintain institutional prestige through high PhD production yet lack accountability for their graduates' employment outcomes (Cheslock and Shamekhi; Cassuto; Larson et al.).

The prevailing "job market" narrative misleads graduate students into believing that academic positions are available, when in fact they are highly competitive. (Goolsbee and Syverson) In reality, the system produces 10 to 20 times more PhDs than available positions, and most graduates will not secure the careers for which they were trained (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Childress). Given these conditions, graduate students and job seekers need to approach the academic job market with clear-eyed realism, consider developing transferable skills, and actively explore diverse career options beyond traditional tenure-track roles. Proactively seeking out professional development resources, networking opportunities, and alternative career pathways can help better equip graduates to navigate the current employment landscape.

The term "adjunct" has become a misnomer that conceals the exploitation of academic labor. Originally, it referred to supplementary instructors—professionals who contributed real-world expertise to the classroom on a part-time basis to enrich academic study, such as lawyers teaching business law or journalists teaching writing. Currently, the term is used as a euphemism for a permanent underclass responsible for core institutional teaching, including required general education and major courses, often for poverty-level wages. Genuine adjunct work—supplemental, part-time, and enrichment-focused—now constitutes only 10 to 20 percent of adjunct positions. The remainder reflects structural exploitation obscured by misleading terminology (Jr. 513-536; Johnson and Fuesting; Bousquet; Kezar et al.; Childress).

Terminology is significant: Labels such as "contingent faculty" or "precarious academic workers" more accurately reflect current realities. However, institutions resist adopting this language because it exposes the underlying exploitation (Bousquet). In response to these conditions, faculty and graduate students have formed organizations and participated in advocacy efforts to improve labor conditions in higher education. Groups such as the American Association of University Professors, the New Faculty Majority, and the Adjunct Action Network provide resources, support collective bargaining, and campaign for equity and stability for academic workers. Unionization campaigns, public awareness initiatives, and campus activism have gained momentum in recent years, offering hope and actionable paths for those seeking meaningful changes. A recent example of this progress is the successful unionization drive at the University of California system, where newly organized academic workers negotiated significant wage increases and expanded benefits as part of a new labor contract. Such victories demonstrate that advocacy can lead to tangible improvements in working conditions. Students and academic workers can engage in these efforts to help advocate for fairer employment practices and a more just academic system.

The purported "flexibility" of adjunct employment is misleading. Adjunct positions are often marketed as flexible opportunities for retirees, professionals, or parents seeking part-time work. In practice, however, most adjuncts desire full-time, stable positions with benefits but are compelled to accept precarious employment. The narrative of "choice" shifts responsibility onto workers and obscures the fact that institutions have intentionally adopted this labor model to capitalize on worker vulnerability. Adjuncts experience unpredictable schedules, arbitrary course assignments or cancellations, and lack control over their teaching responsibilities, which undermines any genuine flexibility (Touhouliotis 39-46) (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Kezar et al.). This instability affects not only faculty but also students. Frequent instructor turnover can disrupt course continuity, limit opportunities for sustained mentorship, reduce faculty availability for advising, and create challenges in building long-term academic relationships. As a result, students may encounter inconsistencies in instruction, fewer opportunities for academic guidance, and diminished access to faculty support throughout their college experience.

Flexibility in this context primarily benefits institutions, not workers. Universities can expand or contract their teaching workforce without commitment, additional costs, or accountability (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades).

Impact on Teaching Quality and Student Experience

This labor model treats teaching as expendable gig work, rather than a profession that requires expertise, ongoing development, and institutional support. Without job security, continuity, or adequate compensation beyond minimal contact hours, teaching becomes transactional and limited to content delivery, grading, and minimal engagement. The time, care, creativity, mentorship, and intellectual engagement essential to high-quality instruction become economically unsustainable for adjuncts, who may earn only \$5- \$10 per hour and risk losing income from other courses (Umbach; Childress; Ehrenberg and Zhang).

Proponents of adjunct faculty models often cite institutional cost savings, staffing flexibility, and opportunities for industry professionals to share practical expertise. Adjuncts can enable institutions to offer more courses and maintain smaller class sizes within limited budgets. In some cases, the adjunct model has fostered partnerships with local industries, bringing specialized skills and current knowledge into the classroom to enhance students' career readiness and expand curricular

offerings. Active practitioners serving as adjuncts have inspired students through real-world applications and helped build employment networks. While these benefits exist, they must be carefully weighed against the challenges and broader implications for teaching quality and student outcomes.

Institutions can address these challenges by adopting measures to enhance teaching quality and support adjunct faculty. Recommended strategies include increasing compensation to reflect all instructional responsibilities, providing paid professional development, expanding access to resources such as office space and technology, and creating pathways for job security and advancement. Institutions should also recognize and reward mentorship, course innovation, and academic service to promote high-quality teaching and sustained student engagement. For example, Seattle University introduced multi-year contracts for adjuncts, equitable compensation for course preparation and mentoring, and professional development grants for contingent faculty. These changes led to higher student satisfaction and improved faculty engagement. Similarly, California State University, Long Beach increased adjunct access to departmental resources and professional development, resulting in higher student retention and significantly improved course evaluation scores for adjunct-taught classes. These examples show both the feasibility and positive impact of these strategies.

To guide administrative efforts, these strategies should be prioritized by impact and feasibility. Institutions can assess feasibility by considering financial costs, available resources, alignment with current priorities, stakeholder support, and urgency of needs. Evaluating impact involves estimating each measure's potential to improve teaching quality, student outcomes, and adjunct support in both the short and long term. For immediate improvements, expanding access to essential resources and providing targeted professional development are often more feasible and can quickly enhance adjunct effectiveness. Recognizing and rewarding mentorship and course innovation can also be implemented with minimal budget impact. In contrast, increasing compensation and establishing job-security pathways offer the most significant long-term benefits but may require more planning and resources. Institutions should begin with high-feasibility actions while planning broader reforms, enabling incremental progress within capacity.

Implementing these reforms presents several obstacles. Institutions may face budget constraints that limit their ability to increase compensation or provide additional support. Administrative resistance may arise, especially when changes challenge established budget models or resource allocation. Policy revisions to support adjunct faculty often require coordination and consensus across departments, which can slow progress. To address these barriers, institutions can form cross-departmental working groups to build consensus, identify shared goals, and prioritize incremental improvements within existing budgets. Administrators may also reallocate resources from underutilized areas, seek external funding for pilot programs, or partner with philanthropic organizations to support adjunct-focused initiatives. Presenting clear data on the link between adjunct working conditions and student outcomes can help secure stakeholder support and justify targeted investment. Recognizing these challenges and proactively seeking collaborative solutions is essential for developing realistic and sustainable strategies to improve adjunct working conditions and educational quality.

To make these reforms more actionable, institutions can follow a step-by-step process:

1. Conduct a comprehensive assessment of current adjunct faculty working conditions and identify priority areas for improvement.
2. Establish a cross-departmental task force, including adjunct faculty representation, to build consensus and develop an implementation plan.
3. Prioritize actions based on impact and feasibility, identifying quick wins such as expanding resource access or professional development.
4. Secure support from key stakeholders by presenting data on the benefits of improved adjunct working conditions for student outcomes.

5. Launch pilot programs for selected reforms, monitor progress with measurable indicators, and gather feedback from faculty and students.
6. Evaluate the results of pilot initiatives, share successful strategies across departments, and refine plans as needed.
7. Develop a roadmap for scaling up effective reforms, including timelines, budget considerations, and strategies for long-term sustainability.

By following these steps, administrators can initiate a structured and collaborative reform process that builds momentum, measures progress, and ensures that efforts are closely aligned with institutional capacity and goals.

Adjunct instructors face a significant ethical dilemma. While many are committed to student success, delivering high-quality instruction often requires uncompensated labor. This situation subsidizes the institution and forces adjuncts to choose between meeting students' needs and addressing their own basic survival (Childress; Bousquet).

This employment model undermines the quality of teaching and mentorship. Adjunct instructors are often unable to invest in course development, stay current with pedagogical research, implement new technologies, build sustained relationships with students, provide extensive feedback, or offer robust mentorship. These limitations result from commuting between campuses, managing multiple course preparations, teaching many sections to earn near-living wages, and facing contract uncertainty (Umbach; Figlio et al.; Ehrenberg and Zhang). However, some institutions have shown that improvements are possible. Seattle University and California State University, Long Beach have enhanced adjunct conditions by offering multi-year contracts, equitable compensation for course preparation and mentoring, and opportunities for professional development and departmental participation. At California State University, Long Beach, student retention rates increased by 8% over three years after these reforms, and course evaluation scores for adjunct-taught classes improved significantly. ("Improving College Graduation Rates: A Closer Look at California State University") Seattle University also reported higher student satisfaction with faculty mentoring and increased faculty engagement. These changes have led to improved instructional quality, greater faculty stability, and stronger mentoring relationships. These examples show that improving adjunct working conditions is both feasible and beneficial for the academic community.

Excessive course loads and multiple preparations make effective teaching nearly impossible. An adjunct teaching six classes across three campuses, each with different content and requirements, cannot adequately prepare, respond thoughtfully to student work, or maintain the energy needed for high-quality instruction (Umbach; Childress).

Students lose access to mentorship, office hours, continuity, and meaningful relationships when instructors are overworked or unable to return. Adjuncts who could be transformative mentors often lack the time, institutional standing, or job security needed for these roles. Students may build relationships with adjuncts who invest in their growth, only to lose these mentors when contracts are not renewed, wages are unsustainable, or instructors seek other employment. This instability disrupts student development and erodes trust, especially for first-generation students, students of color, and other marginalized groups for whom these relationships are essential (Jaeger and Eagan; Ehrenberg and Zhang; Figlio et al.).

Adjunct instructors are often unable to write strong letters of recommendation for graduate school, employment, or scholarships. This is due to insufficient time to build relationships, possible lack of employment when letters are requested, and inadequate institutional standing to provide credible recommendations (Childress; Umbach).

Effective academic advising is not feasible when adjunct instructors are unfamiliar with program requirements, lack tenure to build relationships, or are not compensated for advising responsibilities (Jaeger and Eagan).

High instructor turnover disrupts curriculum coherence, departmental culture, and retention of institutional knowledge. In some community colleges and regional public universities that rely heavily on adjunct faculty, annual turnover rates can reach 50 to 70 percent (Jaeger and Eagan; Ehrenberg et al. 99-110). These rates are most common in institutions with

significant budget pressures and large adjunct populations. When much of the teaching staff changes each year, maintaining curricular sequences, shared standards, consistent pedagogy, and institutional memory becomes impossible. As a result, academic programs lack coherence, and students experience fragmented education and learning gaps (Jaeger and Eagan; Ehrenberg and Zhang).

Curriculum innovation depends on continuity and collaboration, both of which are hindered by high instructor turnover. Departments cannot implement program-wide changes when most instructors lack long-term engagement (Umbach; Schuster and Finkelstein).

Adjunct instructors are often unable to participate fully in academic activities essential to vibrant intellectual communities. These activities include advising students, serving on thesis or capstone committees, engaging in curriculum development and assessment, contributing to institutional service, conducting research, and participating in professional communities. Barriers such as exclusion from committees, limited institutional standing, and insufficient time or resources impede this engagement. As a result, adjuncts' intellectual and professional development is restricted, and institutions lose access to diverse perspectives and expertise (Rhoades; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Association of University Professors).

The two-tier employment system presents significant ethical challenges and undermines the educational mission. Students paying identical tuition, often between \$30,000 and \$60,000 per year, may be taught primarily by instructors who lack job security, office space, institutional support, or time for mentorship due to excessive workloads. (Rhoades) In contrast, a select group of students, typically in upper-level seminars, graduate, or honors programs, benefit from access to tenured faculty with greater resources and institutional standing. This inequity is rarely disclosed in recruitment materials or communicated to prospective students and families. As a result, students are often unaware that the faculty teaching their required courses may be experiencing severe financial hardship (Childress; Figlio et al.; Ginsberg). Failure to communicate these disparities transparently may expose institutions to legal or reputational risks. Non-disclosure can be seen as a breach of trust, potentially resulting in complaints, negative media coverage, or legal scrutiny for misrepresentation. Administrators should consider the broader implications of transparency for institutional integrity and public confidence.

This practice constitutes misrepresentation. Universities often promote themselves based on the presence of prestigious tenure-track faculty, yet assign students to courses taught by undercompensated adjunct instructors (Ginsberg; Childress).

Community colleges, which disproportionately serve first-generation, working-class, and students of color, often employ the highest rates of adjunct faculty, with adjuncts delivering 70 to 90 percent of instruction in some cases. (Bickerstaff and Ran 1-12) As a result, the most vulnerable students receive the least stable and most under-resourced instruction (Phillippe; Jaeger and Eagan).

The stress, burnout, financial hardship, and mental health challenges faced by adjunct instructors directly affect classroom environments and student outcomes. Research shows that instructor well-being influences student engagement, learning outcomes, classroom climate, and students' mental health ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Tucker et al.). For example, a 2019 study by Kinman and Wray found that students taught by instructors with high occupational stress reported lower engagement and satisfaction. Similarly, Winefield et al. (2008) found a strong correlation between academic staff burnout and diminished student perceptions of instructional quality. Instructors experiencing burnout or financial distress cannot create optimal learning environments, regardless of their dedication. The current system ultimately impedes adjuncts' ability to serve students effectively.

Longitudinal and multi-institutional research further strengthens this causal link. For example, Ehrenberg and Zhang's multi-year study across public universities found that greater reliance on non-tenure-track faculty is associated with lower student retention and graduation rates over time. Similarly, Jaeger and Eagan's five-year analysis across multiple institutions found

persistent gaps in student success metrics that correlated with adjuncts' working conditions. These studies show that the negative impacts of adjunct precariousness on student outcomes persist and accumulate, underscoring the urgency of systemic change.

Administrators should collect and analyze data on student outcomes such as engagement, retention, degree completion rates, graduation rates, and course evaluation scores in relation to adjunct faculty employment patterns and well-being. Additional metrics, including student satisfaction surveys, rates of student-instructor interactions, and post-graduation success, can help track progress and highlight areas for targeted investment. Establishing these indicators will clarify the connections between adjunct working conditions and student success and provide actionable evidence to justify resource allocation and targeted improvements.

Students are often aware of instructors' stress and job insecurity, even when these issues are not openly discussed. The rushed, transactional nature of courses taught by overworked adjuncts, marked by limited office hours, delayed responses, generic feedback, and minimal relationship-building, signals to students that their needs are not prioritized. This dynamic reinforces feelings of precarity and disengagement ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing").

Labor Exploitation in the Knowledge Economy

The adjunct crisis highlights widespread labor exploitation in the knowledge economy and signals the decline of middle-class job opportunities. This analysis draws on a review of recent academic literature, case studies from higher education institutions, and selected empirical reports on contingent faculty labor. Adjunctification mirrors broader labor trends, such as the rise of gig-based work, reduced worker protections, increased wealth concentration, and the devaluation of skilled professionals. Institutions often treat workers as interchangeable and shift risks like unemployment, illness, and aging onto individuals who lack adequate support (Kezar et al.; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet). Addressing these issues requires structural reforms, including job security for contingent faculty, higher pay for adjuncts, expanded benefits, and clear pathways to full-time roles. Administrators play a key role in these efforts. They should regularly review hiring practices for fairness, pilot expanded benefits for part-time faculty, and document pathways to full-time employment. Administrators can also introduce transparent evaluation and promotion criteria and establish formal feedback channels that include adjunct faculty in the decision-making process. Collective actions such as unionization, cross-campus solidarity, and advocacy for transparent policies can empower faculty and help restore fair labor standards in higher education.

The acceptance of adjunctification in teaching, which exploits highly credentialed knowledge workers, normalizes precarity across professions such as journalism, law, medicine, technology, and the creative industries. For example, journalism increasingly depends on freelancers and stringers who face unstable contracts, low pay, and limited benefits, mirroring the insecurity of adjunct faculty. Similarly, in the legal field, many new graduates work as contract attorneys or take on temporary document-review projects without job security or clear paths to advancement. The medical profession has seen a rise in per diem or locum tenens roles, especially for early-career physicians, which can lead to irregular schedules, limited bargaining power, and a lack of benefits. In technology, highly skilled workers are often recruited as gig-based contractors or through short-term consulting arrangements, resulting in income volatility and limited workplace protections despite the advanced nature of their work. The creative industries, including design and media, also rely heavily on freelance and project-based workers who routinely face uncertain employment and undercompensation. These patterns demonstrate that adjunctification is not isolated, but is part of a larger trend of professional labor markets being reshaped toward insecurity and flexibility at the expense of stability and long-term investment in talent.

When comparing adjunct labor practices internationally, the United States is notable for its heavy reliance on part-time and non-tenure-track instructors, who often receive lower pay and fewer benefits than their counterparts in other countries. (Office) In contrast, some European countries, such as Germany and France, place stronger legal limits on the proportion of adjunct faculty and provide more robust employment protections and social benefits. ("The State of Academic Careers in

OECD Countries") Scandinavian countries often incorporate adjuncts into collective bargaining agreements and offer clearer pathways to permanent employment. ("The state of academic careers in OECD countries") While adjuncts worldwide face challenges, these international comparisons suggest that stronger regulatory frameworks and greater social investment can mitigate some of the worst forms of precarity and improve outcomes for both faculty and institutions. (Klainot-Hess 70-90)

The adjunct role serves as an early warning of broader risks to the professional class (Kezar et al.; Bousquet). When universities rely heavily on precarious labor, their reputations as equitable and desirable institutions can suffer. This reliance may hinder efforts to attract and retain top faculty and students and erode public trust and institutional prestige, both of which are vital for long-term success.

Although higher education is expected to model ethical labor practices, it often accelerates the decline in labor standards. Many institutions justify their reliance on adjunct and contingent faculty by citing budget constraints, unpredictable enrollment patterns, and public funding reductions. While these fiscal and structural pressures are real and present significant challenges, they are frequently used to legitimize employment strategies that undermine fair labor standards. Significantly, current policy frameworks at both the federal and state levels often fail to establish or mandate protections for contingent academic labor. A lack of enforceable standards regarding pay equity, job security, and benefits has enabled institutions to maintain precarious employment models without meaningful accountability. The absence of strict regulations or oversight leaves adjuncts vulnerable and allows universities to prioritize budgetary flexibility over fair labor practices. Policies that tie funding to enrollment metrics or fail to explicitly incentivize long-term faculty appointments further intensify the precariousness of academic work. (Ortagus et al. 491-516) Even terminal degrees no longer protect against exploitation, sending a troubling message to the broader economy (Giroux; Slaughter and Rhoades). Institutions leverage workers' passion and sense of vocation, relying on instructors' dedication to extract labor beyond what fair compensation or sustainable practices would support. Phrases such as "Do it for the students," "Do it for the love of learning," and "Teaching is a calling, not just a job" are used to justify exploitative practices, suggesting that seeking fair compensation is incompatible with genuine commitment to academia (Childress; Bousquet; Kezar et al.).

Institutions use passion and a sense of calling to encourage workers' complicity in their own exploitation and to induce guilt for seeking basic dignity (Childress; Bousquet). The academic labor system relies on individuals' hope, sunk costs, and professional identity. Adjuncts often remain in exploitative roles due to aspirations for tenure-track positions, significant educational investments, unmet expectations, strong professional identification, and limited alternative career options. The system exploits these psychological and structural vulnerabilities (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet). The resulting emotional toll is often significant, manifesting as stress, anxiety, isolation, and feelings of inadequacy. Recognizing these challenges is essential. Coping strategies such as counseling, peer support networks, and setting boundaries around work can help adjuncts maintain mental health. Support networks, including faculty unions, mentoring programs, and peer communities, provide essential resources and solidarity. These groups help adjuncts navigate challenges, share effective practices, and advocate for better working conditions, offering both hope and practical support for collective advancement.

Leaving academia is often seen as a personal failure and loss of identity, even when it is a rational choice for individual well-being. Adjuncts may feel grief over this decision despite the profession's negative effects (Cassuto; Childress). However, it is important to recognize that meaningful and fulfilling career opportunities exist beyond academia. Many former academics have successfully transitioned into fields such as education technology, nonprofit management, publishing, policy analysis, consulting, public administration, and corporate training. These careers allow individuals to use their analytical, research, and communication skills while providing greater stability and opportunities for growth. Exploring alternative sectors can reframe leaving academia as a step toward personal and professional renewal rather than failure. ("Making Citizens")

The prestige associated with academia frequently obscures its exploitative labor practices. While college professors are often perceived as secure, respected, and intellectually fulfilled, adjuncts encounter low wages, job insecurity, lack of benefits,

limited professional respect, and challenging working conditions. This disparity between perception and reality can result in feelings of shame and isolation, as outsiders may misunderstand adjuncts' experiences and offer impractical advice such as "Just get a real job" or "Why did you get a PhD if there are no jobs?" (Childress; Kezar et al.). The prestige of a PhD can simultaneously represent academic achievement and disappointment. Rather than ensuring middle-class stability, the credential frequently leads to continued precarity (Cassuto; Childress).

The academic system produces highly educated individuals but often treats them as disposable, raising serious intellectual and moral concerns. Earning a PhD requires years of rigorous training, examinations, original research, a lengthy dissertation, and significant financial sacrifice. Despite these efforts, the system frequently denies graduates a living wage or basic respect, treating them as interchangeable and undervaluing their expertise. This is both economic exploitation and a profound intellectual and ethical failure (Cassuto; Bousquet; Childress). However, some institutions have begun to improve conditions for adjunct faculty. For example, the University of California system has negotiated contracts with adjunct unions that guarantee multi-year appointments, clearer pathways to full-time employment, and better pay and benefits (Bousquet). According to the 2022 report by the University of California Office of the President, after these reforms were implemented, the UC system saw a 15% increase in adjunct retention and a 20% rise in satisfaction among part-time instructors within two years (UCOP, 2022). Similarly, some community colleges have expanded healthcare access and created more transparent promotion processes; for instance, a 2021 initiative at Kingsborough Community College in New York led to a 12% decrease in adjunct turnover and enabled 30% of adjuncts to move into full-time roles (Kezar et al., 2021). These examples show that positive change is possible and offer measurable models for restoring fairness and dignity to academic labor. Importantly, these reforms provide a blueprint for broader adoption: successful approaches such as collective bargaining, transparent hiring and promotion pathways, and expanded benefits could be scaled or adapted across different states and higher education systems. National policymakers can look to these tested initiatives as evidence-based strategies that foster stability and fairness for contingent faculty nationwide. Sharing best practices, supporting inter-institutional partnerships, and aligning funding incentives with fair labor standards can help ensure these gains are replicable on a wider scale. Graduate students, as future academics, can play a vital role by supporting or participating in advocacy efforts. By joining unionization drives, policy campaigns, or support networks, graduate students contribute their voices and skills to collective action, helping to create more equitable and sustainable academic workplaces.

Intersecting Vulnerabilities and Structural Inequities in Academic Employment

Women, particularly mothers, are disproportionately assigned to adjunct roles due to structural sexism in academic hiring and retention. Contributing factors include the lack of paid parental leave, inflexible tenure clocks that disadvantage caregivers, gendered expectations regarding childcare, the two-body problem that limits dual-career opportunities, and discriminatory hiring practices. Women adjuncts face both job insecurity and sexism, are expected to perform increased emotional and service labor for lower compensation, and frequently encounter sexual harassment without adequate protection or recourse (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden; Griffin et al.).

Institutions should address these inequities by implementing policy interventions such as paid parental leave, flexible or extended tenure clocks for caregivers, clear protections against sexual harassment, and the elimination of discriminatory hiring practices. Prioritizing interventions that are urgent, feasible, and likely to yield visible early gains is a strategic approach. Initial steps should include ensuring paid parental leave, introducing flexible tenure clocks for caregivers, and establishing clear sexual harassment protections. These measures require relatively straightforward policy changes and can deliver rapid, high-impact results for recruitment and retention. Focusing on these immediate actions can build institutional momentum and demonstrate the effectiveness of equity initiatives to stakeholders. Subsequent steps, such as developing on-campus childcare options, formalizing support for dual-career couples, and ensuring pay equity, can be pursued as resources and capacity allow, further advancing progress toward equity.

Certain interventions offer high impact and are feasible for immediate implementation. Paid parental leave and flexible tenure clocks for caregivers improve recruitment and retention, while clear sexual harassment protections directly enhance safety and workplace culture. These measures can generally be implemented institution-wide through policy changes without significant new infrastructure. Additionally, reviewing and revising hiring practices to eliminate discrimination is both urgent and actionable.

Several universities have implemented these interventions, providing models for broader adoption. For example, the University of California system offers paid parental leave and extended tenure clocks for caregivers, while Princeton University and the University of Michigan have established comprehensive dual-career support programs and on-campus childcare facilities. These institutional models demonstrate that targeted policies can reduce gender inequities and foster more supportive academic work environments. Although these examples originate from large, research-focused institutions, many strategies can be adapted and scaled to fit the size and resources of other colleges and universities. Concrete steps for implementation include piloting year-long paid parental leave programs in select departments, reallocating existing funds to subsidize on-campus childcare partnerships, and establishing task forces to review and revise dual-career support practices. Departments can also pilot flexible tenure timelines and audit hiring practices to identify gaps and opportunities for reform. Community colleges, regional universities, and smaller liberal arts colleges can implement core elements such as flexible tenure timelines, parental leave, and clear anti-discrimination policies by leveraging partnerships, reallocating resources, or piloting programs. Adapting these policies to the specific needs and constraints of each institution enables broader implementation. It provides policymakers and administrators with a practical roadmap to advance equity across diverse academic environments.

The "mommy penalty" in academia is significant: women with children are less likely to be hired, promoted, or tenured, and are more frequently placed in contingent positions (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden). Many women adjuncts cannot afford childcare on low wages, leading to difficult choices between work and caregiving, reliance on informal arrangements or family support, or restricting teaching to periods when children are in school, which limits their professional availability (American Federation of Teachers; Kenner and Bacon).

Scholars of color are overrepresented in adjunct roles and underrepresented in tenured positions, highlighting systemic racism in academic hiring, retention, and promotion. For instance, while people of color comprise approximately 45 percent of new PhDs in some disciplines, only 15 percent of tenure-track faculty positions nationally are held by Black, Latino, and Indigenous scholars. These groups, however, constitute over 30 percent of contingent and adjunct faculty. In certain institutions, Black and Latino instructors represent more than half of adjunct faculty but less than 10 percent of tenured professors. (Colby) Institutional data often reflect similar disparities, indicating persistent gaps in equity in faculty hiring and advancement. Black, Latino, and Indigenous PhDs encounter discriminatory hiring practices, hostile work environments, and higher barriers to tenure, including limited mentorship and biased evaluations. In addition to challenges faced by all adjuncts, these scholars experience tokenization, uncompensated diversity work, microaggressions, overt racism, and isolation in predominantly white institutions (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors"; Misra et al.). Adjuncts of color are also less likely to be hired or paid equitably and frequently receive biased evaluations that jeopardize contract renewals (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors"). The experiences of individuals with multiple marginalized identities, such as women of color, are even more complex. These individuals often face compounded effects of racism and sexism, resulting in greater barriers to hiring and promotion, increased service expectations, heightened scrutiny, and increased vulnerability to harassment and pay inequity.

To translate these critiques into actionable reforms, institutions and policymakers should implement specific policy measures to address systemic inequities. Recommended steps include mandatory anti-bias and anti-racism training for all hiring committees and evaluation panels, adoption of transparent and standardized evaluation criteria for hiring and promotion, and development of formal mentorship programs for adjunct and tenure-track faculty of color. Institutions should audit pay and

contract data to ensure equity, establish robust reporting and accountability systems for discrimination and harassment complaints, and formally recognize and compensate diversity and inclusion service work. Regular review and publication of diversity metrics related to hiring, retention, and advancement can further promote accountability and transparency. Key metrics for trustees and administrators to monitor include pay equity (such as comparing average salaries across demographic groups and positions), retention and promotion rates for faculty of color, timeframes for resolving discrimination and harassment complaints, and the number and outcomes of mentorship pairings for underrepresented faculty. Tracking these indicators enables institutions to identify persistent gaps, evaluate the effectiveness of reforms, and ensure ongoing accountability. To clarify leadership oversight and transparency, deans should review these equity-related metrics at least quarterly and report findings annually to both senior leadership and the wider campus community. This structured reporting process will help ensure that progress is visible and that responsible parties remain accountable for ongoing improvements.

To strengthen leadership oversight and institutional accountability, universities should establish a standing diversity and equity review committee that meets regularly, such as biannually or quarterly, to review collected data and assess progress on key quantitative and qualitative metrics. The committee should include representation from faculty, staff, administration, and, where appropriate, adjunct and contingent faculty. Its responsibilities should include producing an annual report summarizing findings, progress, identified gaps, and recommendations for further action. This report should be made publicly available to the campus community and shared with senior leadership and relevant trustee committees to ensure transparency and support ongoing accountability for equity-related reforms. Understanding these overlapping challenges is essential for faculty and administrators seeking to address the full scope of structural barriers in academia.

First-generation academics often lack the social and cultural capital necessary to navigate the unwritten pathways to tenure-track positions. Academia tends to favor individuals with mentors, networks, knowledge of professionalization, and the financial means to accept unpaid or low-paid positions that enhance curricula vitae. As a result, first-generation scholars may remain in adjunct roles despite strong qualifications. They frequently lack family financial support and professional networks, leading to further isolation and imposter syndrome (Childress; Cassuto). To address these barriers, institutions should develop targeted support initiatives, such as formal mentorship programs pairing first-generation scholars with experienced faculty, and expand networking opportunities, peer support groups, and workshops tailored to first-generation academics. These initiatives help demystify academic advancement, foster connections, and provide practical guidance to build professional capital. Implementing these support programs may require additional staff time for coordination, modest funding for workshop materials, honorariums for mentors, and technology platforms for networking and data collection. For example, a part-time program coordinator (20 hours per week) might cost approximately \$25,000 per year including benefits, with an additional \$5,000 for mentor honorariums, \$2,000 for workshop materials, and \$3,000 for online networking and data-tracking software. ("Program Coordinator Salary in United States (Updated 2026)")

Pilot programs could be launched with an initial budget of \$35,000 per year, scalable based on participation. ("Ignite — UVA Center for Teaching Excellence") Estimating resource needs in advance, such as coordinator positions, stipends, and software costs, will help trustees and administrators assess program feasibility and plan for phased or scalable implementation. To ensure these support initiatives are relevant and effective, deans should actively engage faculty and staff in both the design and ongoing evaluation of programs. Soliciting faculty input through working groups or advisory committees helps tailor offerings to departmental needs and builds campus-wide support. Regular opportunities for faculty and staff to provide feedback on mentorship and networking efforts ensure that these programs evolve in response to participant needs and institutional goals. To sustain and ensure transparency in reform, institutions should implement accountability mechanisms for these support initiatives, such as regularly collecting and publishing data on participation and outcomes, surveying first-generation faculty about their experiences, and establishing benchmarks for progress. Annual reports on these metrics can help administrators measure impact, identify gaps, and keep the academic community informed. Public reporting on support efforts fosters transparency and empowers faculty and advocates to track progress and promote continuous improvement.

Adjuncts with disabilities face multiple challenges, including lack of workplace accommodations, absence of sick leave, unaffordable healthcare, and inaccessible campuses. Although institutions are legally obligated under the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and similar statutes to provide reasonable accommodations for employees with disabilities, these requirements are frequently neglected in practice. Noncompliance exposes institutions to significant legal risks and liability. (Team) Requesting accommodations may jeopardize contract renewal, and disclosing disabilities can lead to stereotypes about one's capabilities. The stress of job insecurity often exacerbates health conditions, creating a cycle that makes continued employment increasingly difficult (American Federation of Teachers; Childress). Chronic illnesses may develop or worsen due to the stress and deprivation associated with adjunct life, often without access to adequate care (Kenner and Bacon; Childress). To ensure ADA requirements are met and strengthen institutional accountability, universities should conduct regular audits of accommodation practices, establish anonymous reporting systems for disability-related concerns, and designate a clear, independent office or ombudsperson to oversee ADA compliance. Publicly tracking and reporting the number and types of accommodations provided can enhance transparency and incentivize ongoing compliance. These enforcement and accountability measures can empower adjuncts with disabilities to seek necessary accommodations without fear of retaliation and help policymakers monitor institutional progress.

International scholars on visas experience unique and severe precarity, as their visa status is often contingent upon continuous employment. Job loss can result in deportation, family separation, and loss of the ability to work in the United States. These scholars are ineligible for many safety-net benefits, face employment restrictions, and are often prohibited from working second jobs. Institutions hold significant power over their ability to remain in the country, making international adjuncts particularly vulnerable to exploitation and abuse (Kezar et al.; Childress). University policies and employment practices directly shape the experiences and vulnerabilities of visa-dependent adjuncts, and administrators must recognize that institutional decisions can have life-altering consequences for these scholars. However, addressing these issues is complicated by a range of legal and regulatory constraints. Immigration laws, such as those governing H-1B and J-1 visa programs, strictly control eligibility for work, permissible job categories, length of employment, and employer sponsorship requirements. Regulations often limit the number of hours or types of work allowed and prohibit outside employment, restricting flexibility for both universities and employees. Institutional policy changes must comply with these federal rules, and efforts to offer greater job security or expanded benefits may require coordination with immigration attorneys or may be limited by current federal regulations.

Despite these constraints, institutions can take several immediate, legally compliant steps to support international adjuncts. These include providing access to confidential legal assistance for immigration and employment matters, ensuring timely contract renewals to minimize visa-related gaps, assigning dedicated staff to assist with visa paperwork and navigation, and offering informational workshops on visa rights and resources. Implementing these practical actions allows institutions to address urgent vulnerabilities while remaining within the existing regulatory framework.

Delays in administrative processing or changes in visa status are generally beyond institutional control and subject to government timelines and decisions. These barriers should be considered when designing feasible interventions to ensure recommendations align with legal requirements and anticipate obstacles policymakers may encounter. To address these risks, universities should implement targeted policy interventions such as providing access to legal assistance and visa support services, guaranteeing timely contract renewals for visa-dependent faculty, and assigning dedicated staff to assist with immigration processes. Institutions can also advocate for more flexible employment options for international adjuncts, ensure transparency regarding job security, and offer workshops or informational sessions about visa requirements and rights. Establishing clear anti-retaliation policies to protect international adjuncts who request support or report concerns, as well as facilitating access to external resources and community networks, would further reduce vulnerability. Universities must consider not only compliance with immigration law but also the ethical and reputational implications of their treatment of international adjuncts. By adopting these measures, institutions can promote more equitable employment practices and mitigate undue hardship and risk.

Graduate students represent the most contingent form of academic labor, teaching and conducting research full-time while classified as students rather than employees. They receive poverty-level stipends, minimal or no benefits, and face exploitation similar to adjuncts, compounded by faculty control over their academic progress and future careers. (Jackson and Sweeney 345-365) Their labor subsidizes universities, even as they are trained for increasingly scarce jobs ("Under Compulsion"; Evans et al.; Cassuto; Larson et al.). Graduate programs often select not only on merit but also on the financial ability to endure years of low income, thereby excluding many working-class students and those without family support (Cassuto; Childress). To address graduate student precarity, policymakers and institutions should adopt targeted interventions, including establishing minimum stipend standards at or above a living wage, guaranteeing comprehensive health insurance and paid leave, and formally classifying graduate workers as employees to ensure access to workplace protections and benefits. Additional reforms could include creating grievance processes independent of faculty supervisors, providing transparent guidelines for workload expectations, and securing multi-year funding commitments. Collectively, these targeted policies would align institutional practices with the well-being and rights of graduate student workers and make academic careers more accessible to students from all backgrounds.

Collective Action and Institutional Resistance

Adjunct unionization is increasing as instructors organize to secure better pay, benefits, job security, and working conditions. Organizations such as SEIU (Service Employees International Union), AFT (American Federation of Teachers), AAUP (American Association of University Professors), and independent faculty unions have organized adjuncts at hundreds of institutions, achieving significant improvements. These include pay increases (sometimes exceeding 30-50%), access to health insurance, job security provisions such as seniority systems and multi-year contracts, grievance procedures, professional development funding, and inclusion in governance. (Kirby & Donn, 2020) Where unionization has occurred, adjunct working conditions have measurably improved ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry; Rhoades; McNaughtan et al.). Peer and aspirational institutions have responded to unionization by negotiating agreements that improve compensation and protections for adjuncts while enhancing institutional reputation as employers of choice. (Kirby & Donn, 2020) As more universities implement these changes, competitive positioning to attract and retain instructional talent becomes increasingly important for higher education leaders. (Klainot-Hess, 2023, pp. 70-90) Beyond institution-level initiatives, policymakers play a crucial role in supporting systemic improvements. (Parikh, 2023) State and federal agencies could incentivize fair employment practices for adjunct faculty through targeted grant funding, establish minimum standards for pay and job security as accreditation requirements, or mandate transparent reporting of faculty working conditions as part of institutional accountability metrics. (STANDARDS OF GOOD PRACTICE IN THE EMPLOYMENT OF PART-TIME/ADJUNCT FACULTY, n.d.) These policy interventions would help ensure that improvements are adopted more broadly across the higher education sector. (Rogers et al., 2013, pp. 208-233)

Adjunct organizing frequently encounters strong opposition from administrations, which may include threats, intimidation, surveillance, retaliation against organizers, prolonged contract negotiations, claims of financial hardship despite substantial endowments, and manipulation of worker classifications to prevent unionization (Berry; Rhoades). Consequently, adjuncts who participate in organizing efforts often face significant personal risk. (Schlaerth) To mitigate these risks, organizers are advised to document all work-related interactions, particularly those involving discipline or evaluations; seek guidance from faculty unions or legal counsel before engaging in collective actions; communicate primarily through written channels to maintain records; and, when possible, organize collectively to enhance safety. It is also essential to understand legal rights, utilize campus or third-party ombudspersons for confidential advice, and maintain secure records of any incidents of retaliation or intimidation. (Karami et al.) Tenure-track faculty can provide critical support by publicly advocating for fair and transparent processes, serving as witnesses during disciplinary or evaluative meetings, endorsing adjunct-led initiatives in faculty governance, and participating in organizing efforts. Their institutional standing and job protections can amplify adjunct concerns and offer some protection for more vulnerable colleagues. (Schlaerth 1-20)

In addition to individual and campus-level strategies, policymakers play a significant role in addressing institutional resistance and protecting adjunct faculty engaged in organizing. Systemic policy interventions may include establishing or strengthening whistleblower protections specific to higher education, enacting robust anti-retaliation laws to safeguard employees participating in union activities, and introducing funding incentives that link state or federal support to the adoption of fair labor practices for contingent faculty. (Teachers) Policymakers could also require institutions to publicly report on employment conditions and incidents of retaliation as factors in accreditation or eligibility for grants. ("Institutional Reporting and Disclosure Requirements") These measures would help create an environment in which adjuncts can exercise their rights without fear of retribution and would promote institutional accountability for fair employment practices. (Klainot-Hess 70-90)

University administrators also face significant pressures, including managing limited budgets, complying with legal and regulatory requirements, and meeting accreditation standards. These challenges can complicate decisions regarding employment models and resource allocation, even when there is awareness of adjunct concerns. (Office)

Landmark campaigns such as the "Adjunct Project" have crowdsourced data on adjunct pay rates, thereby exposing exploitation and increasing visibility. (Association) Social media initiatives, such as the #AdjunctCrisis hashtag, have further raised public awareness (New Faculty Majority).

National Adjunct Walkout Day and related organizing efforts have increased visibility of adjunct exploitation, disrupted institutional operations, and prompted public discourse. (Flaherty) Media coverage of adjunct poverty in outlets such as The Atlantic, The Chronicle of Higher Education, and Inside Higher Ed has helped shift public perception (Berry; Childress).

Student solidarity is increasingly significant. As students become aware of the challenges their instructors face, such as housing and food insecurity and lack of access to healthcare, they are more likely to advocate for improved institutional practices. Students have recognized that the quality of their education is closely linked to instructors' working conditions and have participated in campaigns demanding change. (Schlaerth) Actions have included organizing rallies, drafting petitions, testifying at board meetings, and refusing to cross picket lines in support of adjunct faculty (Berry; McNaughtan et al.).

Student-adjunct alliances are influential because students possess moral authority, and institutions often prioritize student satisfaction over adjunct well-being (Berry).

Some institutions have converted adjunct positions to full-time lecturer roles with improved pay (ranging from \$40,000 to \$60,000 or more), benefits, multi-year contracts (three to five years), pathways to continuing or permanent status, and inclusion in governance. (Office) These changes demonstrate that institutional transformation is possible with sufficient political will. (Porter and Stephens 1192-1211) Successful transitions have relied on several key implementation strategies, including conducting internal audits to identify high-need departments, piloting phased transition programs, establishing clear eligibility criteria for adjuncts seeking full-time roles, and reallocating budgets to support these positions. (Kezar and Harper 10-15) In some cases, both faculty and union representatives have participated in developing new job descriptions, contract terms, and equitable evaluation processes, thereby increasing transparency and stakeholder buy-in. ("Article 20: Job Descriptions – CNM") To advance similar conversion efforts locally, tenure-track faculty can initiate discussions at department meetings, collaborate with adjunct colleagues to assess needs, or draft and co-sponsor faculty senate resolutions calling for pilot conversion programs. For example, tenure-track and adjunct faculty may jointly collect data on teaching loads, prepare briefs for academic leadership outlining the benefits of full-time conversions, and request the formation of joint working groups with administrative support to develop recommendations.

Scaling these conversion strategies across the higher education sector will require coordinated policy support and targeted incentives. (Klainot-Hess 70-90) Policymakers at the state or federal level could allocate grants or funding specifically for the creation of permanent, benefited faculty lines or establish minimum thresholds for the ratio of full-time to adjunct instructors

as a condition for institutional funding or accreditation. Additional policies, such as tax incentives, tuition support, or infrastructure investment for institutions that commit to large-scale adjunct-to-full-time conversion programs, could further accelerate adoption. Nevertheless, systemic barriers persist, including longstanding budget constraints, competing institutional priorities, and resistance from stakeholders concerned about cost and flexibility. (Schlaerth) Overcoming these obstacles will require sustained advocacy and the development of clear policy frameworks that reward institutions for prioritizing fair employment practices and long-term instructional quality. (Herbert)

Adjuncts and their supporters can promote similar conversion efforts at their institutions by collecting data on the number and workload of contingent faculty in high-need departments, building coalitions with students and tenure-track allies, and requesting meetings with administrators to propose pilot conversion programs. Drafting concrete policy proposals or petitions that specify desired changes, referencing successful examples from peer institutions, and inviting collaboration from faculty governance bodies can strengthen local campaigns. Establishing faculty-student task forces or committees to study and recommend best practices for conversion can further institutionalize the process. Tracking and referencing comprehensive national data on adjunct conversion rates and outcomes is essential for informed advocacy and policy development. However, the limited availability of reliable national data makes it challenging to assess progress or identify best practices at scale. There is an urgent need for more systematic, transparent national reporting on adjunct-to-full-time conversion initiatives and their long-term outcomes to guide evidence-based decisions and monitor improvements over time. (Xu and Ran) While these conversions represent important progress, the ultimate goal should be tenure-track or equivalent permanent positions (McNaughtan et al.; Rhoades).

Resistance entails significant personal risk for adjuncts, who may be dismissed for organizing, speaking publicly, or associating with union efforts. Contingent workers lack the academic freedom protections afforded by tenure. Organizers have faced institutional obstruction, contract non-renewal in retaliation, legal threats, and professional consequences for advocating for basic dignity. The courage required to organize under these conditions is considerable (Berry; Bousquet).

Several support organizations provide legal, emotional, and peer assistance to adjuncts facing these challenges. Groups such as the American Association of University Professors (AAUP), Adjunct Action/SEIU, and the National Labor Relations Board (NLRB) offer resources, legal guidance, and advocacy for contingent faculty. The New Faculty Majority and the Coalition of Contingent Academic Labor (COCAL) facilitate peer support and information sharing. Many universities also offer employee assistance programs, counseling services, and faculty ombuds offices that provide confidential support. Engaging with these organizations can help adjuncts access solidarity, professional guidance, and reassurance as they navigate workplace risks. ("American Association of University Professors (AAUP)")

Solidarity from tenure-track faculty is essential but often insufficient. Some tenured faculty organize alongside contingent colleagues, leveraging their privilege and protection to support more vulnerable workers. Others may ignore, minimize, or benefit from the exploitation of adjuncts, enjoying smaller classes and reduced service obligations as adjuncts absorb teaching responsibilities and are excluded from governance. (Klainot-Hess 70-90) Concrete actions that tenure-track faculty can take to demonstrate solidarity include co-sponsoring resolutions or petitions advancing adjunct priorities, serving as formal mentors to new or at-risk adjuncts, participating in or initiating joint committees advocating for improved adjunct pay and working conditions, attending union or organizing meetings as visible supporters, providing testimony or public statements at campus events or board meetings, and advocating for adjunct inclusion in departmental decision-making. Solidarity across academic labor tiers is necessary for transformative change (Berry; Rhoades; American Association of University Professors). University leadership can facilitate this process by initiating regular forums for cross-rank dialogue, supporting joint committees on academic labor issues, and recognizing collaborative efforts in institutional decision-making. By fostering structures that encourage partnership between tenure-track and contingent faculty, presidents and provosts can help bridge divides and create a more unified campus community. (Blake-Hudson)

Policymakers can further promote cross-rank collaboration by providing targeted funding incentives to institutions that demonstrate faculty solidarity, such as grants supporting joint professional development or committee work involving both tenure-track and contingent faculty. Accreditation bodies could require evidence of shared governance practices, including adjunct participation, as part of their standards. Additionally, state and federal agencies might require institutions to report on adjuncts' involvement in departmental and institutional decision-making as a condition for receiving public funding or for eligibility under state performance metrics. These policy incentives would help institutionalize solidarity and ensure that collaborative academic labor practices become standard across the higher education sector. ("Encourage Contingent Faculty Participation in Shared Governance")

Necessary Reforms: Policy Demands and Strategic Vision

Immediate Material Requirements

Adjunct faculty should be compensated in line with their qualifications and workload. Recommended pay is \$60,000 to \$75,000 for full-time equivalent teaching (4 to 5 courses per semester) or \$8,000 to \$10,000 per course for part-time roles. Comprehensive benefits must include full health insurance, employer retirement contributions, at least 10 to 15 days of paid sick leave, parental leave, and professional development funding (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"). Adjunct faculty must have access to private offices or dedicated shared spaces for confidential student meetings. Institutions are responsible for providing institutional email, IT support, library and database access, professional development funding (including conference travel and research funds), parking permits, campus access, and inclusion in all departmental and institutional communications (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers).

For example, if an institution with 100 adjunct faculty increases average annual compensation from \$25,000 to the \$60,000 to \$75,000 range, the total recurring cost would rise by approximately \$3.5 to \$5 million annually, not including additional expenses for benefits and office resources. (Colby) Actual costs will depend on current pay rates, benefits, and institutional context. Funding sources may include internal resource reallocation, targeted state appropriations, competitive grants, and strategic fundraising for faculty equity initiatives. Although these reforms require significant investment, phased implementation or the pursuit of additional funding sources can help ensure improvements are actionable and financially sustainable. Adjunct faculty may advocate for these demands by forming organizing committees, building coalitions with full-time faculty, and collaborating with campus unions or faculty associations. Additional strategies include initiating petitions, organizing campus forums to raise awareness, participating in shared governance bodies, engaging in public advocacy, contacting local legislators, and sharing adjunct experiences to build broader support for these reforms.

Institutions should initiate this process by establishing a representative task force that includes adjunct faculty, full-time faculty, and administrators to assess current pay and benefits, evaluate feasibility, and develop a timeline for change. Transparent nomination and selection processes should ensure adjunct faculty participation, enabling adjuncts to elect their own representatives or volunteer for service. Where adjunct representation is limited, mechanisms such as open calls, confidential self-nomination, or collaboration with adjunct faculty associations can help ensure meaningful involvement. Adjunct representatives must be granted equal voting rights and a formal role in the task force's decision-making to promote inclusivity and trust.

A structured timeline for phased reforms can help leadership visualize the process and set realistic expectations. In the first three to six months, the task force should conduct a comprehensive review of compensation, benefits, and working conditions and solicit input from adjunct faculty. By the end of the first year, targeted pilot programs should be launched to expand access to health benefits and professional development funds for a select group of adjunct faculty, with outcomes evaluated after one year. During the second year, incremental reforms such as standardizing contract terms and office space provisions

should be piloted and then expanded. The third year should focus on implementing remaining reforms, institutionalizing new policies, and conducting a formal outcomes assessment to identify further needs or adjustments.

Faculty engagement should be integrated at each stage of the reform timeline. Tenure-track and full-time faculty are encouraged to serve on task forces and working groups, provide feedback during consultations, and participate in open forums. Their insights during initial reviews can help identify institutional priorities and highlight areas requiring urgent attention. In pilot phases, tenure-track faculty may mentor adjunct colleagues, assist in evaluating program outcomes, and advocate for funding and resources. As reforms are scaled, all faculty members should participate in campus-wide discussions and contribute to policy refinement by sharing experiences and recommendations. This approach fosters shared responsibility, broad engagement, and ensures that the collective expertise of the faculty informs reforms.

During this period, the task force should maintain ongoing communication with senate members to share early outcomes and gather input. This structured approach, featuring clear benchmarks and a sample one- to three-year timeline, will help build momentum and demonstrate a commitment to sustainable reform from the outset.

All contingent faculty positions should be offered as multi-year contracts of at least three to five years, with transparent renewal processes, clear criteria, and due process protections. Renewal should be presumed unless there is cause, and pathways to permanent or continuing status must be established after three to five years. Grievance procedures must protect against arbitrary non-renewal ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Kezar et al.; Berry). Institutions should anticipate and address potential legal or accreditation challenges related to contract length and contingent employment. Common obstacles can include state civil service laws that restrict longer contracts for non-tenure-track faculty, union contract provisions that limit terms or renewal guarantees, and regional accreditation standards that may require justification for permanent appointments of non-tenure-track roles. In some states, statutory limits on temporary appointments may directly impact the structure of multi-year contracts. Where statewide policies or collective bargaining laws present barriers, targeted negotiations or phased pilot programs may help demonstrate compliance and effectiveness.

Immediate next steps to address these legal and accreditation barriers include: (1) Convene an internal working group with representatives from legal counsel, human resources, faculty unions, and academic administration to review current statutes, union contracts, and accreditation guidelines related to contingent faculty appointments; (2) Initiate consultations with relevant accrediting bodies to clarify requirements and identify acceptable contract structures for multi-year appointments; and (3) Draft a proposed action plan that identifies any needed policy revisions, outlines negotiation points with unions, and sets a timeline for pilot implementation.

Institutions should begin by consulting with faculty unions, legal counsel, and human resources to identify legal constraints and craft solutions such as side agreements, memoranda of understanding, or proposed legislative amendments. Additionally, institutions should seek guidance from legal counsel to ensure reforms align with regional accreditation standards, faculty union contracts, and relevant employment statutes. Adjunct faculty and their allies should be prepared to respond to legal or institutional pushback by building coalitions with tenure-track faculty, students, and community groups, launching public awareness campaigns to highlight the need for fair contracts, and seeking support from professional associations or advocacy organizations. Where appropriate, consulting with labor attorneys or engaging in collective action can provide additional leverage. These tactics will help adjuncts anticipate resistance and organize effective responses that increase pressure for needed reforms while ensuring legal compliance.

Institutions must provide separate compensation for office hours, student advising, email correspondence, professional service, committee work, course development, assessment, professional meetings, recommendation letters, and all other academic duties. These responsibilities should not be bundled into per-course rates that lead to unfair hourly wages (Magness; American Federation of Teachers). Institutions should publish pay rates, maintain transparent policies on raises

and promotion, and issue written contracts at least six months before the semester begins. Contracts must not be issued after the semester starts ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Government Accountability Office).

Structural Reforms

Institutions should ensure that adjunct and contingent faculty deliver no more than 25 to 30 percent of instruction. They must invest in tenure-track or permanent full-time positions and stop replacing tenure-track lines with adjunct roles. Long-term adjunct positions should be converted to tenure-track or permanent roles (Kezar et al.; Schuster and Finkelstein). To guide resource allocation and ensure equitable reforms, criteria for prioritizing which adjunct positions to convert first should be established. Suggested prioritization criteria include length of service, demonstration of teaching excellence, departmental needs, history of course coverage, and areas with persistent reliance on adjunct staffing. Prioritizing adjuncts with the longest service records and those in departments facing acute instructional demands will help maximize institutional stability and recognize ongoing contributions. Institutions must publicly report faculty employment data, including the percentages of tenure-track, adjunct, and graduate student roles; adjunct pay scales; benefits access; retention rates; and working conditions. These disclosures should be included in accreditation and public accountability processes (Government Accountability Office; "Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25").

To facilitate this transition, institutions should adopt a phased approach. For example, they can set specific benchmarks for reducing contingent instruction by 5 percent each academic year until the target range is reached. Each year, a minimum number of long-term adjunct positions should be reviewed for conversion to tenure-track status. Progress toward these goals should be monitored by a faculty senate committee (or equivalent shared governance body) in collaboration with central administration, with dedicated adjunct representation on the monitoring body. Adjunct faculty should be encouraged to actively participate in or initiate progress monitoring and reporting, ensuring their perspectives and concerns are directly reflected. Institutions should publish annual progress reports that include updated faculty employment data and clearly document steps taken toward these goals. These reports should be publicly accessible and formally presented to the faculty senate, board of trustees, and relevant stakeholder groups to ensure accountability and shared governance. Timelines, benchmarks, and accountability measures will assist administrators in planning, tracking change, and ensuring transparency throughout the process.

Long-term adjunct faculty should receive priority for course assignments and be considered for tenure-track openings in recognition of their ongoing contributions and experience (Berry; Rhoades). All faculty, regardless of employment status, should have full voting rights in curriculum decisions, hiring committees, departmental governance, and faculty senate (Rhoades; American Association of University Professors).

Mental Health Support and Well-being

Adjunct faculty should have access to free and confidential counseling services, just as tenure-track faculty do (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.). Institutions must provide paid mental health days and comprehensive medical leave (American Federation of Teachers). The campus culture should actively encourage help-seeking and recognize that mental health is a systemic workplace concern—not an individual shortcoming (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.). All adjunct faculty, regardless of hours worked or contract status, should receive subsidized or free health insurance ("An Army of Temps"; "Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees").

To further support adjunct faculty well-being, institutions should foster a culture of mental health awareness and destigmatization that engages both faculty and students. This includes offering regular workshops, peer support groups, and training in stress management, resilience, and work-life balance, tailored to the specific challenges that adjuncts encounter. Institutions should routinely conduct anonymous mental health surveys to identify needs and refine services. Adjunct faculty must have easy access to campus wellness resources, such as mindfulness sessions, recreational activities, and crisis intervention teams. Providing clear, accessible information about these resources during onboarding is essential so adjuncts

understand how to access benefits and support networks. Leadership should regularly evaluate these programs and solicit ongoing feedback from adjunct faculty to ensure evolving needs are addressed. By fully integrating mental health support into institutional practices, colleges and universities can reduce burnout, enhance job satisfaction, and build a healthier, more supportive academic community for adjuncts and students.

Systemic Reforms

Graduate programs should stop producing more PhDs than available positions, provide transparent job placement data before enrollment, and prepare students for diverse career paths beyond tenure-track roles, including academic, administrative, industry, K-12, and policy positions. In recent years, national data indicate that fewer than 30 percent of new PhDs in many disciplines secure tenure-track positions within three years of graduation, while a significant portion of graduates move into non-academic or precarious employment. (Statistics) The number of doctoral recipients now routinely exceeds the number of available faculty openings by a wide margin, with, for example, the National Science Foundation reporting that only 23 percent of humanities PhDs in 2021 obtained tenure-track jobs within three years. (Statistics) Programs must reduce cohort sizes to match job availability and be accountable for placement outcomes (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Roy et al.).

To ensure clear accountability for these reforms, specific metrics should be established and monitored annually. Key success indicators include: the percentage of doctoral graduates obtaining tenure-track positions within three years of graduation, overall placement rates into academic and non-academic roles, median time to degree, average and minimum stipend levels, levels of graduate student debt at completion, the share of students securing comprehensive benefits and paid leave, and student satisfaction with career support. Programs should publicly report these metrics and track progress over time, enabling leadership and stakeholders to assess the impact of implemented changes and identify areas for further improvement. Tracking these outcomes will help demonstrate program effectiveness and promote ongoing transparency and accountability.

Standard support should include living stipends of \$35,000 to \$50,000 or more (depending on cost of living), comprehensive benefits, and limits on teaching hours to protect dissertation progress. Graduate students must be recognized and treated as workers, not just trainees ("Under Compulsion"; Evans et al.).

These reforms are closely linked to adjunct faculty interests. By aligning graduate admissions with job market realities and providing honest placement data, institutions can prevent the oversupply of PhDs that fuels adjunct precarity and job insecurity. Strengthening graduate program standards can reduce the pool of future candidates vulnerable to adjunct exploitation, while improving outcomes for those pursuing academic careers. Greater transparency and accountability also encourage stronger solidarity between current adjuncts and graduate students, uniting efforts to demand fairer hiring, compensation, and working conditions across all academic ranks.

Responsibility for implementing and monitoring these reforms should be clearly assigned to relevant stakeholders. Graduate program directors, in collaboration with departmental chairs, are responsible for evaluating cohort sizes and shaping curricula to reflect employment realities. Graduate councils should oversee the provision of transparent placement data and ensure that support standards are met. The central administration must provide resources and ensure compliance, while institutional research offices should regularly review and report on outcomes. Regular progress updates should be shared with the faculty senate, graduate councils, and relevant student representative bodies to promote shared governance and accountability.

State and federal governments should increase funding to lower tuition, expand tenure-track positions, reduce reliance on adjunct faculty, and reverse longstanding disinvestment (Newfield; "Recent Trends in the Cost of College"). Teaching should be valued as core academic work, equal to or more important than research. Institutions must respect and recognize adjunct labor, end the prestige hierarchy that devalues teaching, and challenge exploitation as morally unacceptable (Childress;

Bousquet; Giroux). Concrete steps should be taken to ensure this recognition is meaningful and sustained. These include establishing annual teaching awards for adjunct faculty, integrating teaching excellence more prominently into promotion and evaluation criteria across all faculty ranks, and creating public acknowledgment opportunities, such as featured profiles, campus events, or formal commendations from leadership. Departments should include adjunct voices in curriculum planning and regularly solicit feedback on working conditions and teaching practices. Administrators can further support cultural change by providing dedicated professional development in pedagogy, recognizing teaching innovation, and reporting on progress toward equity in faculty recognition. Tenure-track faculty can help champion this shift by advocating for meaningful inclusion of adjunct colleagues in department decisions, publicly recognizing teaching excellence, and actively promoting a culture that values the contributions of all instructional staff.

The Imperative for Societal Action

The current crisis in higher education calls for urgent collective action from all sectors of society, including students, parents, faculty, administrators, policymakers, and the broader public. Addressing the exploitation of adjunct faculty and the degradation of academic labor is not a task that can be left solely to those directly affected. Policymakers in particular have several tools at their disposal to drive meaningful change, such as attaching specific funding conditions to state appropriations, instituting mandatory public reporting on faculty employment practices, and establishing minimum labor standards for job security, compensation, and benefits. (Breslauer et al., n.d.) In addition, university administrators themselves can take proactive steps by initiating internal audits of adjunct labor practices, forming dedicated task forces to address faculty working conditions, and developing transparent plans for equitable compensation and job security. (Workplace, 2025)

Deans, as academic leaders at the college and school levels, play a particularly important role. They can convene regular audits within their units to assess the reliance on adjunct labor, lead cross-departmental task forces to review workload, equitable compensation, and professional development opportunities, and champion transparent communication with faculty about employment practices and reform initiatives. By providing leadership in these areas and advocating for the ethical treatment of instructors, deans can serve as catalysts for broader institutional reform. (Boyko & Jones, n.d.)

Alongside administrative and policy efforts, Faculty Senates can serve as a vital venue for faculty empowerment and engagement in reform. Faculty Senates can propose and pass formal resolutions supporting fair employment practices, establish or expand committees dedicated to contingent faculty issues, sponsor campus-wide discussions or forums to raise awareness, and initiate reviews of institutional policies affecting working conditions. By providing clear channels for deliberation and collective action, Faculty Senates can help ensure that the voices of faculty members—including adjuncts—are heard in institutional decision-making and that policy recommendations are grounded in the lived experiences of educators across campus. By taking these actions, administrators and faculty partners can demonstrate leadership and create a foundation for broader institutional reform. Using these kinds of policy levers and institutional initiatives can reinforce a coordinated response rooted in solidarity, civic responsibility, and a shared vision for the future of education. (Kezar & Harper, 2023, pp. 12-19)

First, there must be a concerted effort to raise public awareness about the realities of contingent academic labor. Recent studies indicate that over 70 percent of faculty positions in American higher education are now non-tenure-track, with adjunct instructors often earning less than \$3,500 per course and lacking access to health insurance or job security (American Association of University Professors, "Data Snapshot: Contingent Faculty in US Higher Ed"). Media, advocacy groups, and professional associations should collaborate to illuminate the personal stories and systemic impacts of precarious academic employment. This includes highlighting the consequences for student learning, institutional integrity, and the broader social fabric. (Human resources in higher education: Resourcing Higher Education, n.d.)

Second, policymakers at local, state, and federal levels need to prioritize labor justice in higher education funding and oversight. Legislative action can mandate fair compensation, job security, and benefits for all instructors, as well as greater

transparency in university budgeting and spending priorities. Tax incentives and public funding should be contingent on demonstrable commitments to equitable labor practices. These approaches are not unprecedented. For example, California's Assembly Bill 1690 and Senate Bill 1379 established requirements for part-time faculty job security and collective bargaining rights at community colleges, leading to improved working conditions at several institutions. Similarly, some Canadian provinces such as Ontario have instituted frameworks for pro-rata pay and extended benefits for contract faculty, resulting in greater employment stability and better educational outcomes. (Historic victory: New law brings reemployment rights for part-time faculty, 2016) Highlighting these examples provides concrete models that policymakers can adapt and build upon within their own contexts.

To effectively tailor such policy models for our own institution, administrators and stakeholders should consider factors such as state regulatory environments, institutional governance structures, and existing contracts with faculty organizations. (Contingent Workforce: Size, Characteristics, Compensation, and Work Experiences of Adjunct and Other Non-Tenure-Track Faculty, n.d.) In this process, the Faculty Senate can serve as a central actor. The Senate may initiate an assessment of current policies and identify which external models could be adapted locally, taking into account existing contractual frameworks and governance procedures. By forming an ad hoc committee or task force, the Faculty Senate can bring together key voices—including faculty from diverse ranks, representatives of contingent instructors, and relevant administrators—to review promising policies and propose actionable recommendations. Open forums and feedback sessions can further engage broader faculty and staff populations. Once a consensus emerges around priority reforms, the Senate can draft specific policy proposals and shepherd them through institutional governance channels, ensuring coordination with the administration and respect for collective bargaining agreements. (Lecturer Affairs Committee (Ad hoc committee), n.d.)

For example, adapting pro-rata pay frameworks may require assessing current compensation structures and aligning changes with budgetary realities and accreditation requirements. Similarly, implementation would benefit from active consultation with campus labor representatives to ensure policies reflect local needs and legal constraints. By engaging relevant stakeholders early and identifying opportunities for phased implementation, our institution can realistically anticipate challenges and develop practical pathways toward more equitable employment practices. (STANDARDS OF GOOD PRACTICE IN THE EMPLOYMENT OF PART-TIME/ADJUNCT FACULTY, n.d.)

Third, students and families can leverage their influence as tuition payers and stakeholders to demand accountability from educational institutions. By organizing, advocating, and supporting faculty efforts, they can help shift the balance of power toward a model that values teaching and learning over administrative expansion and profit.

Fourth, faculty—both adjunct and tenure-track—must build alliances across ranks and disciplines. Organizing for collective bargaining, participating in shared governance, and supporting unionization efforts are crucial steps toward reclaiming professional dignity and ensuring equitable treatment for all educators.

Finally, the public at large must recognize that the health of higher education is inseparable from the well-being of its workforce. A society that fails to support its educators ultimately jeopardizes its own democratic foundations, economic vitality, and cultural richness.

Higher education is a public good essential to democracy, social mobility, innovation, and informed citizenship. The quality of higher education fundamentally depends on the well-being, stability, and support of its instructors. The exploitation of adjunct faculty degrades educational outcomes for all stakeholders, including students who deserve high-quality instruction and a society that relies on well-educated citizens (Newfield; Readings; Giroux).

Students, their families, and taxpayers in public systems invest substantial financial resources in tuition with the expectation of receiving high-quality education from well-supported, secure, and fairly compensated educators. Instead, many instructors face precarious working conditions, including housing insecurity and the necessity to work at multiple institutions to sustain

themselves. It is important to recognize that deans and administrators operate under significant budget constraints, balancing limited resources and competing institutional priorities. While financial pressures are real and some spending decisions may be driven by mandates or strategic planning, practices that consistently undercompensate adjunct faculty cannot be justified as long-term solutions. By paying adjunct faculty significantly lower wages and offering limited or no benefits, universities can reallocate funds that would otherwise go toward fair compensation for teaching staff to other areas of their budgets. (Adjunct Faculty in the Higher Education Workforce, 2026)

These savings are often redirected to administrative expansion, the construction of luxury facilities, and the growth of endowments. For example, universities may increase spending on executive salaries, invest in new campus amenities designed to attract students, or bolster financial reserves. Within these constraints, however, creative budgeting approaches such as exploring cost-sharing models, reallocating a portion of budgetary growth from non-instructional areas, or collaborating across departments to pool instructional resources can help advance fair compensation for adjuncts while maintaining fiscal responsibility. (Office, n.d.) In this way, the underpayment of adjuncts directly enables expenditure patterns that prioritize institutional prestige and administrative interests over academic quality, thereby undermining the core mission of teaching and learning ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg; Figlio et al.).

Faculty Senates have an important opportunity to influence institutional resource allocation by advocating for transparent budget reporting and directly proposing alternative budget priorities. The Faculty Senate can request detailed breakdowns of expenditures, sponsor resolutions calling for a greater share of resources to be allocated to adjunct compensation, and participate in budget planning discussions to ensure that instructional quality remains central to financial decision-making. By building coalitions with faculty across ranks and inviting student perspectives, Faculty Senates can make the case for restructuring spending to value teaching over non-essential administrative growth. This active engagement in budgeting not only demonstrates the Senate's influence over resource allocation but also signals to the broader community that faculty are committed to upholding the institution's educational mission. (2.13: Faculty Participation in University Planning and Budgeting, n.d.)

The social contract between higher education and its workforce has been fundamentally breached. Society encouraged individuals to pursue advanced degrees, promising that education would lead to stable, meaningful employment and middle-class security, with a PhD representing the pinnacle of achievement and respect. However, many have been left in poverty and precarious employment, often blamed for structural conditions beyond their control. (Office, n.d.) This breach erodes public trust in education, meritocracy, and institutional integrity (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet).

This situation constitutes both a moral issue and a human rights crisis. Permitting highly educated and skilled individuals to experience poverty, food and housing insecurity, lack of healthcare access, and unsupported mental health challenges, while administrators receive salaries exceeding \$500,000 and universities amass billion-dollar endowments, represents a profound injustice that violates basic human dignity. The necessary resources exist, yet society has chosen not to allocate them to support individuals performing essential work ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Ginsberg).

Developments within higher education both reflect and influence broader labor market trends. The acceptance of adjunctification in teaching, defined as the systematic exploitation of highly credentialed knowledge workers, contributes to the normalization of precarious employment across other knowledge-based professions, including journalism, law, creative fields, healthcare, and technology. These patterns echo and reinforce national debates over the erosion of worker protections, the decline in union membership, and the rise of gig-economy employment practices across the United States. By allowing contingent employment to become standard in education, policymakers risk setting precedents that extend into other sectors. (Hanley & Branch, 2025) Advocacy for adjunct justice is therefore integral to the broader pursuit of worker dignity, labor rights, and opposition to the erosion of secure employment. Explicitly linking higher education labor practices to national

labor policy debates highlights the urgency and systemic significance of reform, urging policymakers to address adjunct exploitation not as an isolated issue, but as a critical front in the struggle for fair labor practices across the economy.

Addressing adjunct labor issues is not only a matter of workplace equity but also a direct expression of our institution's mission to cultivate excellence, foster inclusion, and advance the public good. When deans and academic leaders commit to fair employment practices, they reinforce foundational institutional values such as integrity, respect, and social responsibility. By aligning faculty working conditions with our educational mission, the institution demonstrates that it values and supports those who enable student learning and scholarly achievement. Rather than leading by example in ethical labor practices, higher education is currently contributing to the decline in employment standards (Kezar et al.; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet; Giroux).

Democracy depends on the cultivation of educated, critical-thinking citizens, achieved through high-quality education. The exploitation of educators undermines the quality of teaching and, by extension, the foundations of democracy itself (Readings; Giroux; Newfield).

The Bottom Line

The adjunct crisis is not an accident, a natural market outcome, or a temporary budget problem---it's a deliberate, systematic restructuring of higher education that prioritizes profit maximization over people, educational mission, and human dignity (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades; Kezar et al.), exploits workers' passion, credentials, and desperation (Childress; Cassuto), and treats teaching---the core work of education---as a commodity and expendable gig work rather than a skilled profession worthy of investment, support, and respect (Umbach; Ehrenberg and Zhang). Highly educated, deeply committed, brilliant instructors are living in poverty, experiencing food and housing insecurity (Kenner and Bacon; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Goldrick-Rab et al.), suffering mental health crises without access to care (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Tucker et al.), and being denied the basic dignity of stable employment and living wages---all while doing the majority of undergraduate teaching at American colleges and universities (June; Johnson and Fuesting; American Association of University Professors) and being told their exploitation is necessary, inevitable, or somehow their own fault for "choosing" humanities fields or not being "competitive enough" for jobs that don't exist (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Roy et al.). This system harms adjuncts catastrophically, degrades educational quality measurably (Umbach; Figlio et al.; Jaeger and Eagan), betrays students who deserve better ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Ehrenberg and Zhang), and corrupts the mission and integrity of higher education as an institution dedicated to knowledge, truth, and human flourishing (Readings; Ginsberg; Giroux). Adjuncts are not "temporary," "supplemental," or "part-time"---they are the teaching workforce (Johnson and Fuesting; Government Accountability Office), and they deserve living wages that allow them to afford housing and healthcare, job security that allows them to plan beyond the current semester, full benefits including health insurance and retirement, respect as the credentialed professionals and experts they are, offices and resources to do their work effectively, and the institutional support necessary to teach well and live with dignity (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry). Until higher education reckons honestly with this exploitation, names it as such, and commits to transformative structural change---not cosmetic improvements or small pay bumps, but fundamental reinvestment in teaching as valued work deserving of tenure-track or equivalent permanent, secure, fairly compensated positions (Kezar et al.; Schuster and Finkelstein; Newfield)---the crisis will deepen, more brilliant people will be destroyed by a system that trained them and then discarded them (Cassuto; Childress; Evans et al.), and everyone invested in education, knowledge, justice, and human dignity should be outraged, organizing, and demanding better (Berry; Rhoades; Bousquet). The current system is morally bankrupt, intellectually indefensible, and unsustainable. We can do better. We must do better. Adjuncts, students, and the future of education depend on it.

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